A DISSERTATION

SARTRIX RESARTA

The Voice of the Shuttle, the Grammar of the .45, and the Sororal Remainder in Abel Ferrara and Nicholas St. John's Ms. 45 *(1981)*

Ms. 45

ABEL FERRARA • NICHOLAS ST. JOHN • 1981

OCTOBER 2026

Abstract

This dissertation undertakes an exhaustive philosophical, theological, and film-theoretical reading of *Ms .45* (1981), directed by Abel Ferrara from a screenplay by Nicholas St. John, and extracts from it a new normative framework, here termed *hyphantic humanism* (from the Greek *hyphainein*, "to weave"). The film's protagonist, Thana (Zoë Tamerlis, later Zoë Lund), is a mute seamstress in Manhattan's Garment District who is raped twice in a single day, first at gunpoint by a masked man in an alley and then by a burglar in her apartment, kills the burglar with a clothes iron, dismembers him, and, armed with his .45 pistol, conducts an escalating campaign of homicide that culminates in a massacre at her employer's Halloween party, where, costumed as a nun, she is stabbed in the back by a female coworker and dies screaming the only word she ever voices: "Sister!" Existing scholarship has read the film principally as an urban inflection of the rape-revenge cycle (Clover; Read; Heller-Nicholas), as a feminist détournement of the male vigilante film (*Death Wish*, *Taxi Driver*), or as an early document of the Catholic moral vision animating the Ferrara–St. John corpus (Stevens; Brenez). These readings leave unthought the film's most rigorous formal wager: that the heroine's speechlessness, her trade, and her violence compose a single system.

Reconstructing that system through the Ovidian myth of Philomela, the raped and tongueless weaver who sends her testimony to her sister, and through Aristotle's citation of "the voice of the shuttle" as an instrument of tragic recognition, the thesis argues that *Ms .45* stages *a Philomela without Procne*. Thana's textile speech, already alienated in wage labor, is displaced by a *ballistic speech*: a grammar of one sign and one referent whose monosemy guarantees its progressive semantic exhaustion, so that the film enacts with uncommon precision Hannah Arendt's twin claims that violence is mute and that it can destroy power but never generate it. The film is bracketed by two forms of address, the liberal hon-

orific of its title, whose period migrates in the canonical spelling from the courtesy title to the caliber, and the radical kinship term of its final scream. The passage from *Ms* to *Sister* constitutes the film's true itinerary, and the .45 is the failed mediation between them.

Situating this argument across feminist theory (Beauvoir, Brownmiller, Dworkin, MacKinnon, Lorde, hooks, Cixous, Irigaray, Kristeva, Mulvey, Silverman, Butler), the philosophy of violence (Benjamin, Fanon, Sartre, Camus, Arendt, Girard, Nietzsche, Améry), psychoanalysis (Freud, Lacan, Riviere), Catholic moral theology (Augustine, Aquinas), and the humanist tradition (Pico, Kant, Levinas, and Stephanie Jed's demonstration that Florentine humanism was founded upon the rape of Lucretia), the dissertation isolates a *sororal remainder*: the residue of address that violence cannot assimilate and that arrives only as belated anagnorisis. Hyphantic humanism, constructed upon that remainder, conceives the human neither as a sovereign self-fashioner nor as a projectile, but as a texture of address, vulnerability, and concerted speech. *Ms .45* is thereby reclaimed not as a revenge fantasy but as an apophatic tragedy of failed sorority and an exacting, if involuntary, contribution to the critique of violence.

Contents

•	Abstract	i
•	Introduction: The Seamstress and the Projectile	1
I	Fear City: The Political Economy of a Mute Body (New York, 1980–81)	6
II	Authorship as Moral Theology: St. John, Ferrara, Lund, and the Catholic Imaginary of Violation	10
III	Philomela's Loom: Muteness, Textile Speech, and the Voice of the Shuttle	14
IV	Ballistic Grammar: The .45 as Prosthetic Voice and the Semiotic Entropy of Revenge	19
V	The Masquerade and the Unpunished Author: Gaze, Face, and the Death of the Photographer	23
VI	Sparagmos in the Refrigerator: Abjection, Dismemberment, and the Domestic Economy of Revenge	27
VII	The Unconverted Fury: Revenge, Law, and the Critique of Violence from Aeschylus to Benjamin	30
VIII	Rebellion and Its Limit: Fanon, Sartre, Solanas, Dworkin, Camus, Arendt	34
IX	Habit, Habitus, Hallowmas: The Nun, the Martyr, and the Anti-Hagiography of Thana	38
X	"Sister!": Recognition, Sorority, and the Tragedy of the Remainder	42
XI	Constellations: *Ms .45* Among Feminist and Humanist Works	47

XII Toward a Hyphantic Humanism 51
- Appendix: A Semiotic Ledger of the Killings 56
- Select Bibliography 58
- Keywords 65

INTRODUCTION

The Seamstress and the Projectile

> *purpureasque notas filis intexuit albis, / indicium sceleris* ("she wove purple signs into white threads, the evidence of the crime") — Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 6.577–78

> "This oughta make you talk, huh?" — the second assailant in *Ms .45*, a line excised from the 2000 DVD edition

I. *A Film of Few Words About a Woman Without Words*

Ms .45 was shot in four weeks of February and March 1980, frequently without municipal permits, on a budget of roughly sixty-two thousand dollars, from a screenplay that Nicholas St. John mailed to Abel Ferrara and that participants remembered as conspicuously thin, supplemented with dialogue during production. Its first reception assimilated it to the vigilante template: Janet Maslin's notice in *The New York Times* framed it as a woman doing a *Death Wish* job and, while praising Tamerlis's performance and Ferrara's direction, deplored nearly everything else. Four decades of revaluation, from Carol Clover's installation of the film within the rape-revenge cycle to Alexandra Heller-Nicholas's monograph and successive restorations, have converted an exploitation property into a canonical object of American independent cinema. Yet the reappraisal has largely retained the categories of the original dismissal while inverting their valence: where the film was once a feminine *Death Wish*, it is now a feminist one.

The thinness of the screenplay is not incidental to the film's achievement; it is its formal condition. *Ms .45* is a film of few words about a woman without

words, and the economy of its dialogue is the medium in which its central figure becomes legible. This dissertation proceeds from the conviction that the film's laconism constitutes a philosophical position: that it thinks the relation between speech and violence more rigorously than the discourse that has surrounded it, and that this thinking can be reconstructed and extended into an original account of the human.

II. *Three Hermeneutics and Their Remainder*

Three hermeneutics have governed the literature. The first is *generic-structural*: the film is located within a narrative syntax of violation and retribution, analyzed by Clover through the spectator's cross-gender identification and the cycle's urban and rural topographies, historicized by Jacinda Read as a popular negotiation of second-wave feminism, and differentiated by Heller-Nicholas and Claire Henry into a heterogeneous field of revisions. The second is *ideological-adjudicative*: it asks whether the film is feminist or misogynist, liberatory or exploitative, a question that exploitation cinema's double economy, in which the spectacle of violation is sold alongside the spectacle of its punishment, renders formally undecidable. The third is *auteurist-theological*: the film becomes an early station in the Catholic moral cosmology that Ferrara and St. John elaborated through *The Funeral* (1996), as in Brad Stevens's account of Ferrara's moral vision and Nicole Brenez's figural analysis.

Each hermeneutic produces genuine knowledge, and each brackets the same datum. Thana's muteness is treated as a symptom, typically of trauma, or as an allegory of women's silencing, rather than as a structural property of the film's sign-system; her trade is treated as local color; her final scream as irony. Against this tendency, the dissertation isolates seven data whose conjunction it names the *Thana system*:

1. Her muteness is given without etiology: the film neither explains it nor cures it.
2. Her trade is textile: she sews for a male designer in the Garment District.
3. Her first counter-violence is struck with a small glass apple and completed with a clothes iron, an instrument of her trade.
4. Her collapse at work the following day is triggered by the sight of her employer tearing a shirt from a mannequin.
5. She answers her employer in writing ("I'll try") and voices a single word, to a woman, at the moment of her death.
6. Her second assailant's taunt construes rape as the extortion of speech.

7 The first, masked rapist is played by the director under his habitual pseudonym "Jimmy Laine," and he is the one violator the film never brings within range of her weapon.

III. *Four Propositions*

The dissertation advances four propositions, each the burden of a cluster of chapters.

1 **The Philomelan proposition.** *Ms .45* restages the Ovidian myth of Philomela, the raped woman whose tongue is severed and who weaves her testimony for her sister, with a decisive subtraction: there is no Procne. The voice of the shuttle, deprived of its addressee, mutates into the voice of the gun.

2 **The ballistic proposition.** Violence in the film functions as a substitute language, a grammar of one sign whose referent drifts from the individual violator to the category of men and finally to noise. Its trajectory is semiotic entropy, and the film thereby enacts Arendt's thesis that violence is mute and incapable of generating power.

3 **The sororal proposition.** The scream "Sister!" is the remainder that violence cannot assimilate: the addressee absent from the Philomelan structure, the plural subject absent from the rebel's solitary act, and the anagnorisis that arrives only in death.

4 **The hyphantic proposition.** From the negative dialectic of weaving and shooting, an account of the human can be constructed as texture rather than substance, an interlace of address and vulnerability opposed both to the sovereign self-fashioner of Renaissance humanism and to its ballistic caricature.

IV. *Method: Constellation, Symptom, Reparation*

The method is constellational in Walter Benjamin's sense, according to which ideas are to objects as constellations are to stars: the film is read not as an illustration of prior theory but as the point around which heterogeneous texts, from Ovid to Arendt, become mutually legible. It is symptomatic in the sense developed by Louis Althusser's reading of Marx and by Fredric Jameson's *The Political Unconscious*, published in the year of the film's release, according to which what a text cannot say organizes what it does say. And it is, with one qualification, reparative in Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's sense.

The qualification is reflexive. Sedgwick characterized paranoid reading as anticipatory, mimetic, and committed to the exposure of hidden violence; the de-

scription fits Thana's hermeneutic of the city with uncanny exactness, since every approaching man is read in advance as a repetition of the first. Reparative reading assembles and sutures, and suturing is precisely the seamstress's labor, which the film shows to be expropriated, feminized, and invisible. A reparative method that forgot this would reproduce the division of labor it describes; the dissertation therefore stitches while keeping the needle in view.

v. *Ethical and Orthographic Protocols*

Three protocols govern the analysis. First, sexual violence is discussed at the level of structure and representation rather than graphic description, but every act is named for what it was and every agent is named; following Sarah Projansky and Tanya Horeck, the dissertation assumes that the representation of rape is never ideologically neutral and that commentary can reenact what it analyzes. Second, because muteness is a disability before it is a metaphor, the reading heeds David Mitchell and Sharon Snyder's critique of *narrative prosthesis*, the conscription of disability as a crutch for narrative meaning, and holds the literal and figural registers in deliberate tension. Third, the film's ethnic coding, including the killing of a Saudi businessman and his driver, is read through Edward Said's *Orientalism* rather than passed over in silence.

The canonical credit reads *Ms .45*, a spelling in which the period belongs to the caliber. The variant *Ms. 45*, nearly universal in criticism and preserved in this dissertation's title, returns the point to the honorific. The canonical form is used throughout except where the migration of that point is itself the object of analysis, as it is in Chapter One.

vi. *Architecture*

Chapter One reconstructs the film's material conditions: the fiscal and carceral crisis of New York, the harassment economy of its streets, the labor history of the Garment District, and the semantics of a title in which a feminist honorific is grafted onto a caliber. Chapter Two reads the film's authorship as a disputation in Catholic moral theology, tracing its genealogy through Augustine's treatment of violated chastity, Livy's Lucretia, and Stephanie Jed's thesis that humanism was born of a rape narrative, and pairing the film with *Bad Lieutenant* (1992), co-written by its star. Chapters Three and Four form the theoretical core: the first reconstructs the Philomelan structure and the textile genealogy of women's testimony; the second analyzes the .45 as prosthetic voice and anatomizes the entropy of its grammar. Chapter Five addresses gaze, masquerade, and the face, including the meta-cinematic implications of the director's cameo as the unpun-

ished first violator. Chapter Six considers abjection and dismemberment through Kristeva, Euripides, Aeschylus, and the iconography of Judith. Chapters Seven and Eight situate Thana's violence within the philosophy of revenge, from the *Oresteia* to Benjamin, and of insurgent violence, from Fanon to Arendt. Chapter Nine treats the nun's habit as the hinge of garment, habitus, and compulsion. Chapter Ten reads the final scene as tragic recognition. Chapter Eleven sets the film within a comparative constellation of feminist and humanist works, and Chapter Twelve formulates hyphantic humanism and confronts the objections it must survive.

I

CHAPTER ONE

Fear City: The Political Economy of a Mute Body (New York, 1980–81)

1.1 *The City as Precondition*

The New York in which *Ms .45* was shot had spent half a decade rehearsing its own collapse. The fiscal crisis of 1975 produced not only austerity but a semiotics of menace: police and firefighter unions distributed to arriving visitors a pamphlet titled *Welcome to Fear City*, converting municipal labor conflict into a tourist's guide to danger. The Son of Sam murders of 1976–77, whose perpetrator the tabloids first christened the ".44 Caliber Killer," taught the city to name its killers by their ammunition; the blackout of July 1977 supplied the iconography of collapse. Cinema metabolized these materials into a masculine fantasy of restoration. In *Death Wish* (1974), *Taxi Driver* (1976), and *The Exterminator* (1980), the failure of the state's monopoly of legitimate violence, Max Weber's definition of the state itself, licenses its private reappropriation by an armed man.

The structure of that fantasy is archaic. In *Death Wish* the architect Paul Kersey avenges the murder of his wife and the rape of his daughter; the women are the occasion of violence, never its agents. Susan Brownmiller's history of rape in *Against Our Will* (1975) argued that early rape law codified violation as an injury to the property of fathers and husbands, and the male vigilante film reproduces that archaic jurisprudence as melodrama: the woman's body is the site of an offense whose true victim, and therefore true avenger, is a man. *Ms .45* performs its first theoretical act by subtraction. It removes the patriarchal mediator through whom a woman's violation becomes a man's grievance, and assigns the gun to the violated body itself. Ferrara and St. John would later title a film *Fear City* (1984); in 1981 they had already relocated fear from the city's men to its women, and returned it.

1.2 *The Harassment Economy and the Armed Flâneuse*

The film opens not on rape but on its ambient condition: Thana and her coworkers walking home through a gauntlet of solicitation and insult. The sequence establishes what Slavoj Žižek would later call *objective violence*, the systemic violence that constitutes the background against which *subjective* violence, the visible act of an identifiable agent, appears as an interruption. Brownmiller's most contested thesis, that rape is the means "by which all men keep all women in a state of fear," is here spatialized: the street is gendered territory before any crime is committed upon it.

Janet Wolff's essay "The Invisible Flâneuse" (1985) argued that the literature of modernity, from Baudelaire to Benjamin, presupposed a male stroller, and that a woman walking the city at night was legible only as a streetwalker. Thana's nocturnal walks, after her first killings, realize the impossible figure: she becomes a flâneuse only by arming herself, and the city's misrecognition of her as available becomes the lure by which she selects her victims. Her walks are also a solitary, wordless, armed transposition of the Take Back the Night marches that spread through American cities in the late 1970s. The difference between the march and the walk, between concerted presence and isolated violence, anticipates the Arendtian argument of Chapter Eight. The film, moreover, was made for and circulated within the exploitation economy that anti-pornography activists, among them Women Against Pornography, founded in New York in 1979, made the object of their critique; it inhabits the commerce it indicts.

1.3 *The Garment District: Labor, Silence, and the Speaking Commodity*

Thana's workplace is not a neutral backdrop. The Garment District is the historic theater of American women's industrial labor and of its most notorious catastrophe. The shirtwaist strike of 1909, the Uprising of the Twenty Thousand, was carried by young immigrant women; the Triangle Shirtwaist Factory fire of March 1911, in which 146 workers, most of them young immigrant women, died behind a locked exit door, became the founding trauma of American labor reform. The factory's owners, Max Blanck and Isaac Harris, were tried for manslaughter that December and acquitted. By 1980 the district's manufacturing base was in decline and its labor increasingly casualized. Thana sews for Albert, a male designer, among female coworkers, and the film traverses the entire chain of fashion: the atelier where femininity is manufactured, the photographer's studio where it is converted into image, and the street where it is consumed as display. She will kill an agent at each station.

Marx chose textiles to theorize value. In the first chapter of *Capital* (1867) the relative and equivalent forms are worked out through linen and coat, and the

linen is figured as expressing its value in the language of commodities; in the section on fetishism Marx imagines what commodities would say if commodities could speak. Thana is the hyperbolic figure of the producer's speechlessness under the value-form: she makes the coats that speak. Social relations between persons appear as relations between things, and the thing becomes eloquent precisely where the person falls silent. Her collapse at work on the day after her rapes is triggered by the sight of Albert tearing a shirt from a mannequin. The gesture discloses the violent truth of the garment: the mannequin, whose name descends from the Middle Dutch for "little man," is the commodity-body of femininity, and the stripping reenacts violation as an industrial routine.

Silvia Federici's *Caliban and the Witch* (2004) locates the disciplining of women's bodies at the origin of capitalist accumulation, and Iris Marion Young's account of the five faces of oppression (exploitation, marginalization, powerlessness, cultural imperialism, and violence) reads like an inventory of Thana's world. The film is unusual within the rape-revenge cycle in insisting that violation occurs within a political economy, not merely within a psychology, and in making its heroine a worker whose silence is overdetermined: by disability, by gender, and by her position in production.

1.4 *The Migrating Point: Honorific, Caliber, Puncture*

The title is a form of address. The courtesy title *Ms.*, promoted in the late 1960s and institutionalized by *Ms.* magazine in 1972, refuses to index a woman's marital status; it addresses her as an individual rather than as a daughter or wife, and it is the honorific of liberal feminism par excellence. In the film's title, however, the honorific precedes not a surname but a caliber. Where the patronymic or marital name would stand, the signifier that in Lacan's account installs the subject within the symbolic order, there stands a ballistic quantity. The woman released from the name of the father and the husband is reinscribed under the name of the weapon: she is "of" the .45 as a wife was once "of" a husband. The title thus stages, in two syllables and a number, the peril of an emancipation that merely changes its master signifier.

The canonical spelling sharpens the allegory. In *Ms .45* the abbreviation surrenders its period to the caliber, where it becomes the decimal point of a measurement in inches. The point is the minimal mark shared by the needle and the bullet: Latin *pungere*, to prick, yields *punctum*, puncture, and point. Roland Barthes's *Camera Lucida* (1980), published the year before the film's release, defined the *punctum* as a sting, speck, cut, or little hole, and tied it to punctuation. The title's punctuation is therefore a micro-allegory of the whole: the seamstress's point migrates from needle to bullet, and the honorific's courtesy is converted into

ballistic measure. The variant spelling *Ms. 45*, which criticism has overwhelmingly preferred, returns the period to the honorific. Critical tradition has thus re-punctuated the film, performing at the level of orthography its recuperation as a liberal-feminist text.

The title also mimics the tabloid nominalism that named the Son of Sam by his caliber, and outbids it by a hundredth of an inch. Its international release title, *Angel of Vengeance*, supplied the theological register that the American title withheld, naming Thana not by a weapon but by a function in the economy of divine retribution. The two titles divide between them the film's two languages, the ballistic and the sacred, which Chapters Four and Nine examine in turn.

1.5 *Guerrilla Production and the Indexical City*

Shot largely without permits, the film absorbed the city as found: passersby, traffic, the grain of real streets. In André Bazin's terms, the photographic image is an index, a trace of the real comparable to a death mask, and the guerrilla method charges the fiction with documentary residue. The violence of the story is inscribed upon a non-fictional city. The soundscape enforces the same asymmetry: the city is ceaselessly loud, its men voluble and insistent, while the heroine is silent. The street functions as a chorus without a protagonist's voice, and the film's most consistent formal principle is already in place: everyone in New York speaks except the woman whom the city is about to make speak.

II

CHAPTER TWO

Authorship as Moral Theology: St. John, Ferrara, Lund, and the Catholic Imaginary of Violation

2.1 *A Disputation in Two Hands*

Abel Ferrara, born in the Bronx in 1951 and raised Catholic, met the future Nicholas St. John, a pen name, in high school in Peekskill. St. John, a devout Catholic, wrote Ferrara's features from *The Driller Killer* (1979) through *The Funeral* (1996), after which the partnership ended in estrangement; he is reported to have declined involvement in *Bad Lieutenant* (1992) on account of its blasphemous imagery. Critics have long described the corpus as the record of a contest between the screenwriter's belief and the director's secular, convulsive intensity. The most exact name for that form is scholastic. The Ferrara–St. John films constitute a *quaestio disputata* conducted in images: each poses a question of moral theology, rehearses objections, and withholds or scandalizes the expected response. *Ms .45* is the earliest and starkest article in the series, and its question can be stated in the language of the *Summa*: whether it is lawful for a violated woman to take vengeance.

Thomas Aquinas devotes a question of the *Secunda Secundae* to vengeance (II–II, q. 108), treating *vindicatio* as a virtue annexed to justice. Vengeance is lawful, he argues, insofar as the avenger intends a good through the punishment of the wrongdoer, namely his amendment, or at least his restraint, the peace of others, the upholding of justice, and the honor of God; it is unlawful when it takes delight in the evil of the one punished. The criteria are precise, and Thana fails all of them in an instructive way. Her vengeance intends no amendment, since its objects die; no restraint, since it escalates; and no peace, since it multiplies fear. Nor does it take delight: her face, throughout, is impassive. Her vengeance intends something Aquinas's taxonomy lacks a term for, namely *address*.

2.2 *Augustine and the Interiority of Chastity*

The Catholic theology of violation begins with Augustine's consolation to the Christian women raped by Alaric's Gothic soldiers during the sack of Rome in 410 (*De civitate Dei* I.16–19). Chastity, he argues, is a virtue of the mind; it is not lost when the body is forced without the consent of the will. From this premise he mounts a celebrated assault on the Roman veneration of Lucretia, whose suicide after her rape he subjects to a dilemma: *si adulterata, cur laudata? si pudica, cur occisa?* If she was adulterous, why is she praised; if chaste, why was she killed? Lucretia, on this reading, murdered an innocent woman out of a pagan love of reputation.

The Augustinian move is double-edged. It liberates the violated woman from the ancient logic of stain, and it has been read as proto-feminist for that reason. Yet it also relocates the injury from the world to the soul, where it becomes spiritually indifferent; it privatizes the harm, forbids the Roman remedy of self-destruction, and, a fortiori, forbids retaliation, since vengeance belongs to God. *Ms .45* is anti-Augustinian in form and anti-Lucretian in plot. In form, it refuses the interior theater: there is no voice-over, no confession, no access to the will in which Augustine located chastity, so that the film can show only exteriorization. In plot, Thana neither consents nor kills herself; she turns the blade outward. And yet the film ends, as Lucretia's story does, with a knife.

2.3 *Lucretia's Knife and the Birth of Humanism*

Livy's account (*Ab urbe condita* 1.57–60) deserves to be reread in the light of Thana's trade. The contest that sets the catastrophe in motion is a wager among Roman princes over whose wife is most virtuous; riding home unannounced at night, they find the royal wives feasting and Lucretia, late into the night, devoted to wool-work among her maids. Her textile virtue wins the wager and inflames Sextus Tarquinius. After the rape, Lucretia summons her father and husband, testifies, demands vengeance, and stabs herself; Brutus draws the knife from the wound and swears upon it to expel the kings. The Roman Republic is founded upon the violated body of a woman who worked wool. In the classical economy, she speaks and dies; the men act and found.

Stephanie Jed's *Chaste Thinking: The Rape of Lucretia and the Birth of Humanism* (1989) traced how Florentine humanism, from Coluccio Salutati's declamation on Lucretia onward, narrated republican liberty through this story, and argued that humanist philology, a practice of *castigatio* or textual purification, reproduced the logic of chastity: knowledge purified by the excision of the violated body. Jed's thesis supplies this dissertation with its most direct bridge between

feminism and humanism. Humanism, on her account, is not merely compatible with sexual violence; it was narratively founded upon it.

Ms .45 dismantles the Lucretian economy term by term. Its heroine cannot testify, does not die by her own hand, and herself acts. When the knife returns at the end, it is in a woman's hand; no oath is sworn over it and no republic is founded, only a costume party dispersed in panic. The oath is spoken instead by the dying woman, and it is not an oath of vengeance but a kinship term. Brutus's vow against the kings is answered, across two millennia, by a scream addressed to a sister. Ian Donaldson's survey of the myth's transformations, and Shakespeare's *The Rape of Lucrece* (1594), with its long and eloquent complaint, throw the inversion into relief: the tradition made the violated woman voluble before death, and *Ms .45* makes her mute until it.

2.4 *The Nun Diptych:* Ms .45 *and* Bad Lieutenant

Zoë Tamerlis was still a teenager when she played Thana; as Zoë Lund she later co-wrote *Bad Lieutenant* with Ferrara. In that film a nun is raped in a church by two young men, refuses to identify them, and forgives them; the corrupt Lieutenant, after a vision, releases the rapists with money for a bus out of the city and is shot dead shortly afterward. Read together, the two films form a diptych structured by a chiasmus of authorship. In the film written by the believer, the violated woman becomes an armed nun, an angel of vengeance. In the film co-written by the actress who played her, and refused by the believer as blasphemous, a violated nun forgives.

The diptych stages the central crux of Christian ethics in its starkest form. The Pauline sequestration of vengeance, "Vengeance is mine; I will repay, saith the Lord" (Romans 12:19, KJV), is followed within a few verses by its delegation to the civil ruler, who "beareth not the sword in vain" and is "a revenger to execute wrath" (Romans 13:4). The theological origin of the state's monopoly of retribution lies here. Between these verses stands the Sermon on the Mount's counsel not to resist evil (Matthew 5:39). Thana occupies the position of a subject for whom neither God nor ruler repays; the nun of *Bad Lieutenant* occupies the position of one who renounces repayment altogether. Both are brides of Christ, women whose violation is also sacrilege, and both are figures through which Ferrara's collaborators ask whether justice for the violated can be human at all.

2.5 Quaestio*: Whether It Is Lawful for a Violated Woman to Take Vengeance*

The film's position can be set out in the form of an article.

Objection 1. It seems not, for it is written: "Vengeance is mine; I will repay, saith the Lord."

Objection 2. Augustine teaches that chastity resides in the will and is not lost through violence suffered without consent; hence no injury remains to the soul that vengeance could repair.

Objection 3. Private vengeance usurps the public authority to which the sword is entrusted, for the ruler "beareth not the sword in vain."

On the contrary, Aquinas holds that vengeance is lawful when it intends a good: the amendment of the wrongdoer, his restraint, the peace of others, and the upholding of justice.

I answer that the film neither affirms nor denies the proposition; it removes the conditions under which the question can be asked. It depicts a world in which the public sword is not drawn for women, the public authority entering the story only belatedly and peripherally; in which the will is inaccessible, since the heroine has no interior voice; and in which God is present only as a costume. Under these conditions vengeance is neither lawful nor unlawful but *grammatical*: it becomes a mode of speech for a subject denied every other. The film thereby displaces the question from moral theology to semiotics, and the dissertation follows that displacement in Chapters Three and Four.

Reply to Objection 1. The Pauline sequestration presupposes a God who repays. The film's world contains no such repayment, and its international title, *Angel of Vengeance*, names the vacancy: the angel acts because the Lord does not.

Reply to Objection 2. Augustine's consolation interiorizes the injury; the film exteriorizes it entirely, so that what is at stake is not the purity of a soul but the speech of a world.

Reply to Objection 3. The sword is borne in vain where it is never drawn for her. The private avenger appears precisely where the public avenger of Romans 13 has defaulted, which is why the film belongs less to the genre of crime than to the genre of theodicy.

III

CHAPTER THREE

Philomela's Loom: Muteness, Textile Speech, and the Voice of the Shuttle

> "the voice of the shuttle" — Aristotle, *Poetics* 16 (1454b), citing Sophocles' lost *Tereus*

3.1 *The Myth and Its Subtraction*

In the sixth book of the *Metamorphoses* (6.412–674), the Thracian king Tereus, sent to fetch his wife Procne's sister, Philomela, imprisons her in a hut deep in ancient woods and rapes her. When she threatens to proclaim the crime, to fill the forests with her voice and move the stones to pity, he severs her tongue with his sword. Imprisoned for a year, she sets up a loom and weaves purple signs into white threads, the evidence of the crime, and sends the cloth to her sister. Procne reads it in a silence of her own, uses the nocturnal rites of Bacchus as cover to reach Philomela, disguises both of them as Bacchants, and with her kills her son Itys, cooks him, and serves him to Tereus. Pursued, all three become birds.

The homology with *Ms .45* is structural rather than allusive, and its most revealing feature is a subtraction.

Narrative function	Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 6.412–674	*Ms .45* (1981)
Violation	Tereus rapes Philomela in a hut in the woods	Thana is raped twice in one day, at gunpoint in an alley by a masked man and at home by a burglar armed with the .45 she keeps
Silencing	Tereus severs her tongue to prevent testimony	Muteness is given in advance; the second assailant taunts that rape will make her talk

Narrative function	Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 6.412–674	*Ms .45* (1981)
Textile medium	Philomela weaves the crime in purple on white	Thana sews for a designer; her labor belongs to the commodity, not to testimony
Addressee	The cloth is sent to her sister, Procne	No addressee; she writes only to her employer ("I'll try")
Recognition	Procne reads the web and knows the crime	No one recognizes; the city reads the scattered remains as anonymous atrocity
Festival and costume	The Bacchic rites as cover; both sisters disguised as Bacchants	A Halloween party; Thana costumed as a nun
Revenge	The sisters kill Itys and serve him to Tereus	Thana kills men singly, then fires on the men at the party
The meal	A cannibal banquet for the violator	Part of the dead rapist's body ground into hamburger and fed to the landlady's dog; a knife taken from the cake table
Sorority	The sisters act together	The coworker arrives as her killer; "Sister!" is the only word Thana voices
Ending	Metamorphosis into birds	Death; the spared dog finds its way home

Ms .45 is a Philomela without Procne. Every element of the Ovidian sequence returns except the addressee, and the absence of the addressee reorganizes everything else. Testimony becomes impossible because there is no one to receive it; recognition fails because there is no one to read; revenge becomes solitary and therefore indiscriminate; and the festival, which in Ovid is the cover for sororal rescue, becomes in Ferrara the theater of the heroine's death at a sister's hand. Even the cannibal banquet survives, displaced onto an animal, and the knife that ends Thana's life is taken from the table where the party's sweet is to be shared.

3.2 *The Voice of the Shuttle: From Aristotle to Joplin*

Aristotle's *Poetics* classifies modes of recognition and cites, among those contrived by the poet, "the voice of the shuttle" in Sophocles' lost *Tereus*: the woven cloth through which the crime is made known. The textile is thus inscribed at the origin of Western dramaturgy as an instrument of *anagnorisis*, the passage from ignorance to knowledge on which tragedy turns. Geoffrey Hartman made the phrase an emblem of literary language as such, the speech of the mute thing. Patricia Klindienst Joplin's "The Voice of the Shuttle Is Ours" (1984) reclaimed it for feminist criticism: the myth exposes how a violent order silences women, how women's art persists as testimony, and, read through and against René Gi-

rard, how the sisters' revenge risks reproducing the sacrificial logic of the order it answers.

The Ferrara–St. John film adds a historical determination that the myth lacks. Philomela's loom, in her prison, is her own; Thana's labor is not. The shuttle has no voice in the Garment District because it has an owner, and its products speak, in Marx's sense, the language of commodities rather than the language of testimony. Under capital the voice of the shuttle is expropriated into the voice of the garment. That is why Thana's first counter-violence must pass through an instrument of her trade, the iron, and why her subsequent speech must pass through an instrument that is not of her trade at all.

3.3 *Arachne, Penelope, the Fates: A Textile Genealogy of Testimony*

The same book of Ovid opens with Arachne (6.1–145), whose tapestry in her contest with Minerva depicts the gods' sexual violence against mortal women. The goddess tears the cloth, strikes the weaver, and transforms her into a spider after she attempts to hang herself. Nancy K. Miller's "Arachnologies" (1986) made this story a figure for feminist criticism, the practice of reading for the weaver's signature, the trace of a woman's body in the text. Ovid's sixth book is, in effect, a book of weavers who testify to rape and are punished or transformed for it. Its punishing goddess is the same Athena who, in Aeschylus, founds the court that subordinates the Furies, a connection Chapter Seven develops.

Penelope weaves and unweaves Laertes' shroud to defer the suitors; her craft is a temporizing *mētis*, a resistance by delay. The suitors are then slaughtered in the hall at their feast by her returning husband, and the disloyal maids are hanged; Margaret Atwood's *The Penelopiad* (2005) revoices those maids, the women destroyed by the restoration of order. *Ms .45* fuses Penelope and Odysseus in a single figure: the weaver herself performs the slaughter in the hall of the feast, and she is in turn destroyed by a woman acting, wittingly or not, for the restored order.

The Moirai complete the genealogy. Clotho spins, Lachesis measures, Atropos cuts. Thana's name abbreviates *Thanatos*, and her trajectory leads from the first Fate to the third, from the seamstress's thread to the severing of lives. The film is a passage from Clotho to Atropos.

Freud's lecture on "Femininity" (1933) proposed that women's one contribution to the inventions of civilization might be plaiting and weaving, motivated by the wish to conceal a genital deficiency. Luce Irigaray anatomized the specular economy in which woman is constituted as nothing to see; Sadie Plant's *Zeros + Ones* (1997) turned Freud's slight into a counter-history in which weaving becomes the matrix of computation. Thana's trajectory inverts the Freudian

scenario: from the needle that, on Freud's account, conceals lack, to the gun that brandishes a prosthetic plenitude. Rozsika Parker's *The Subversive Stitch* (1984) showed how needlework served both to inculcate femininity, patience, docility, and silence, and to articulate covert resistance. In *Ms .45* the stitch is not subversive; the iron is. The instrument that presses garments into their finished form becomes the instrument that finishes a man.

The first blow, before the iron, is struck with a small glass apple. The emblem of Eve's transgression, the fruit through which theology assigned guilt to women, is here an ornament of feminine domesticity turned weapon. It is also, in the Judgment of Paris, the prize of a beauty contest judged by a man. The film opens its sequence of counter-violence with the symbol of the two charges historically laid against women, guilt and vanity, returned upon a violator.

3.4 *Muteness Without Etiology*

Thana's muteness is never explained. Within disability studies, David Mitchell and Sharon Snyder showed how narrative tends to introduce disability as a deviance requiring explanation, cure, or punishment; *Ms .45* declines the first two, though its ending may be read as the third. The refusal of etiology matters. Muteness here is not a symptom of trauma, since it precedes the rapes; it is a condition, a given position in the film's economy of voice. Thana hears, and she writes: she answers her employer's invitation with a note ("I'll try") and, later, composes a false note explaining the disappearance of her landlady's dog. She is aphonic, not alinguistic. Her language is graphic rather than phonic.

This distribution has philosophical consequences. Jacques Derrida's *Of Grammatology* (1967) diagnosed the phonocentrism of Western metaphysics, its privileging of the voice as self-presence and its degradation of writing as a dangerous supplement. Thana's existence in writing does not overturn the hierarchy; it allocates its values with tragic exactness. Writing is the medium of compliance and deception, addressed to the master and to the landlady. Voice is the medium of truth and recognition, addressed to a sister. Phonocentrism is not refuted but fulfilled, at the cost of a life: the voice arrives as presence at the instant of absence.

Kaja Silverman's *The Acoustic Mirror* (1988) showed how classical cinema confines the female voice to the diegetic interior, binding it to the visible body, while reserving disembodied authority for men; Mary Ann Doane analyzed the fantasmatic unity of body and voice that synchronization produces. Thana escapes acoustic containment only by suffering a more radical exclusion. Michel Chion's *The Voice in Cinema* (1982) described the woman's scream as a "screaming point" toward which narrative films converge, an unspeakable black hole of sound. The rapes in *Ms .45* are not organized around a scream. The screaming point is dis-

placed to the gunshot and deferred to the final scene, where it is fulfilled in an unprecedented form: the scream is articulate. The cry becomes a word.

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988) located the impossibility of subaltern speech not in the absence of utterance but in the absence of a circuit of hearing, exemplified by a woman's bodily act of protest that was misread for decades. Thana's ballistic acts are bodily speech that the city misreads as anonymous crime. Audre Lorde's "The Transformation of Silence into Language and Action" (1977) supplies the decisive formula: "Your silence will not protect you." Lorde's sequence runs from silence to language to action. *Ms .45* reorders it, from silence to action to language, and the reordering is the tragedy. Action without language cannot be heard; language that arrives after action arrives too late to be lived.

IV

CHAPTER FOUR

Ballistic Grammar: The .45 as Prosthetic Voice and the Semiotic Entropy of Revenge

4.1 *The Purloined Phallus*

The gun is an inheritance from rape. It belongs to the burglar who rapes Thana in her apartment, and she keeps it after killing him; the instrument of her violation becomes the instrument of her speech. Lacan's seminar on Poe's "The Purloined Letter" (1956) argued that the displacement of a signifier, not the intentions of those who hold it, determines their positions in a symbolic circuit, so that whoever possesses the letter is reshaped by it. The .45 is a purloined signifier in exactly this sense. Its passage from rapist to victim repositions both, turning the one into a body in pieces and the other into a hunter, but the signifier carries its circuit with it. The position the gun installs is the position of the violator. Nor is the weapon new to her ordeal: the first assailant, too, raped her at gunpoint, so that in both violations the gun was the instrument of compulsion, and the voice she takes up is the voice in which she was twice commanded.

Audre Lorde's axiom, "The master's tools will never dismantle the master's house," here receives one of its most literal cinematic tests. In Lacan's "The Signification of the Phallus" (1958), the masculine position consists in appearing to *have* the phallus and the feminine in appearing to *be* it, a distinction sustained by masquerade. Thana's transformation, the darkened lips and severe dress that accompany her campaign, intensifies the feminine masquerade at the very moment the gun confers the masculine appurtenance. She occupies both positions at once, and the film registers the instability of that conjunction as escalation: a subject that both is and has the phallus cannot stop proving either.

Freud observed in *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) that technology has made man "a kind of prosthetic God," magnificent when he puts on his auxiliary organs, though those organs have not grown onto him and still give him much

trouble. Thana is a prosthetic goddess whose auxiliary organ is a voice. Donna Haraway's "A Manifesto for Cyborgs" (1985) called the cyborg an illegitimate offspring of militarism and patriarchal capitalism, adding that illegitimate offspring are often exceedingly unfaithful to their origins. The .45 is precisely such an offspring, and the question the film poses through it is whether Thana's infidelity to its origin, turning the violator's weapon on violators, can survive her fidelity to its logic.

4.2 *A Grammar of One Sign*

Saussure's *Course in General Linguistics* (1916) established that in language there are only differences without positive terms: a sign means by virtue of what it is not. A language of a single sign is therefore a limit case, and the film runs it to its limit. Every utterance in Thana's grammar is the same, a shot; its referent is, ultimately, a single category, men. The sign's value tends toward zero precisely as its scope tends toward totality: what can be said of everyone signifies nothing about anyone.

Peirce's trichotomy of index, icon, and symbol allows the trajectory to be charted with precision.

- **Index.** The burglar is killed in the act of violation. The violence is contiguous with its cause, as smoke with fire; it is the only killing that an ordinary jurisprudence of self-defense could fully absorb.
- **Error.** A young man who retrieves a bag she has dropped and pursues her through alleys is shot when he corners her. A gesture of retrieval and a gesture of menace have become indistinguishable, and the grammar's first utterance after the index is a misreading. Here Sedgwick's paranoid hermeneutic becomes a weapon: anticipation forecloses the possibility of a good surprise.
- **Icon.** The photographer who solicits her, the pimp who beats a prostitute, the gang who close in to assault her: these are men who resemble the violator in act or posture. The sign now operates by resemblance, and each target is legible as a figure of the first offense.
- **Symbol.** A Saudi businessman and his limousine driver are selected by convention: wealth, foreignness, and the code of the purchasable woman. The sign's conventionality turns ideological, borrowing the culture's Orientalist stereotypes, in Edward Said's sense, and the driver dies by mere association.
- **Stammer.** With a recently jilted salesman she meets in a bar, the gun jams. He takes it, clears it, and shoots himself. The only interlocutor who "understands" her sentence completes it upon himself.

- **Noise.** At the Halloween party, among men costumed as other things, she fires on signs of signs. Selection has no semiotic ground left, and the grammar dissolves into the indiscriminate.

The arc from index to noise is a process of *semiotic entropy*: the progressive loss of differential information in a sign system whose single term is asked to bear an unlimited semantic load. Carol Clover observed that urban rape-revenge, in which the original offender is anonymous, tends toward generalized retribution; the present analysis specifies the mechanism. The first assailant was masked, and therefore had no face to which vengeance could be indexed. A revenge that cannot find its referent must make one of the category, and a category cannot be killed, only multiplied.

The terminus of this entropy coincides with the most contested universal of 1970s feminism. Brownmiller held that rape keeps all women in fear on behalf of all men; Thana's grammar reaches the same universality not by argument but by exhaustion, and the film shows what such a universal costs when it is enacted rather than asserted. The category that Brownmiller's sentence names as the agent of intimidation becomes, at the party, the target of fire, and the costumes ensure that no individual within it can be distinguished from the category.

4.3 *Speech Act Without Uptake*

J. L. Austin's *How to Do Things with Words* (1962) distinguished the locutionary act, the illocutionary act performed in saying something, and the perlocutionary effect produced by saying it, and made the securing of *uptake*, the hearer's understanding, a condition of illocutionary success. Thana's shots are perlocutionarily total and illocutionarily void. They achieve their effect absolutely; they secure no understanding whatsoever. Their addressees die without knowing what was said to them, and the city that receives the scattered remains cannot read them.

Catharine MacKinnon's *Only Words* (1993) argued that pornography is not merely speech but conduct, an act of subordination wearing the costume of expression. *Ms .45* inhabits the converse position in the same debate: Thana's conduct is speech wearing the costume of action. Judith Butler's *Excitable Speech* (1997) criticized MacKinnon's reliance on a sovereign model of the performative, the decree that does what it says, and located the possibility of resistance in the gap between saying and doing, which permits resignification. The ballistic utterance is the absolutely sovereign performative: it does exactly what it "says," and for that reason it admits no reply, no resignification, and no politics. The sovereign performative is the end of language.

Hannah Arendt drew the corresponding conclusion in political theory. Speech and action, she argued in *The Human Condition* (1958), disclose *who* an agent is; violence, being instrumental, discloses nothing. In *On Revolution* (1963) she wrote that violence itself is incapable of speech, and in *On Violence* (1970) that it can destroy power but is utterly incapable of creating it. Thana's campaign confirms every clause. It discloses no "who": the public sphere learns of limbs and corpses, never of a person. It generates no power: no one joins her. It speaks to no one, and therefore it cannot stop speaking.

Elaine Scarry's *The Body in Pain* (1985) showed how torture converts the pretext of interrogation into a demonstration of the regime's power, while pain itself unmakes language, returning its victim to pre-linguistic cries. The second assailant's taunt, that rape "oughta make you talk," is the torturer's logic in miniature: violation framed as the extraction of speech. The film will answer the taunt in its final scene, in a manner Scarry's model does not anticipate.

4.4 *Naming by Caliber*

The tabloid sobriquet ".44 Caliber Killer" and the title *Ms .45* share a modern nominalism that names subjects by their implements. In the public sphere Thana has no name, only a weapon, and her anonymity is the exact correlate of Arendt's thesis: an agent who acts only through violence is disclosed only as an instrument. The caliber replaces the surname because violence replaces speech.

4.5 *The Gun's Two Hesitations*

Twice the grammar halts. Having ground part of the dead rapist's body into hamburger and fed it to her landlady's dog, she ties the animal to a post by the river and draws the gun; the dog survives and, in the film's final image, finds its way home. At the party, stabbed from behind, she turns, aims at Laurie, and hesitates. The grammar's limits are the animal and the woman. Its single sign is gendered all the way down, reserved for men, and its stammer and silences mark the points where something other than ballistic speech insists.

Emmanuel Levinas's essay "The Name of a Dog, or Natural Rights" (1975) remembered a stray dog who greeted Jewish prisoners of war in a German camp as human beings when their guards would not, and called him the last Kantian in Nazi Germany. Phil, whose name carries the Greek root of love, is the one creature in the film that follows Thana's secret by its scent and the one being her weapon spares before the end. The two hesitations are the first appearances of what Chapter Ten will name the sororal remainder: the points at which recognition interrupts the projectile.

V

CHAPTER FIVE

The Masquerade and the Unpunished Author: Gaze, Face, and the Death of the Photographer

5.1 *To-Be-Looked-At-Ness Weaponized*

Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) theorized the image of woman in classical cinema as bearer rather than maker of meaning, coded for "to-be-looked-at-ness," and identified two strategies by which the male look contains the threat she represents: a sadistic voyeurism that investigates, punishes, or saves her, and a fetishistic scopophilia that overvalues her image. *Ms .45* neither abolishes the gaze nor replaces it with a female one. It operationalizes the gaze against itself. Thana's transformation, from girlish plainness to a severe glamour of dark lipstick and dark clothing, converts to-be-looked-at-ness into a lure. The look she solicits becomes the look that draws men within range; the fetish becomes bait; and voyeurism's investigative and punitive functions pass to the woman, who now selects, pursues, and punishes.

Joan Riviere's "Womanliness as a Masquerade" (1929) described an accomplished intellectual woman who, after lecturing with masculine authority, compulsively sought reassurance through flirtation with father-figures, wearing womanliness as a mask to avert the reprisals she feared for having appropriated masculine potency. Riviere's most radical claim was that genuine womanliness and the masquerade are the same thing. Thana literalizes the scenario: her hyper-femininity conceals her possession of the masculine instrument and averts recognition until the instant of the shot. Mary Ann Doane's "Film and the Masquerade" (1982) read masquerade as a distance from one's own image that allows a woman to manipulate femininity rather than coincide with it.

That distance is dramatized in the mirror. After the second rape, preparing to shower, Thana hallucinates the masked first assailant in her reflection, grabbing her breast. In Lacan's account the mirror stage furnishes the ego with its first,

alienating image of unity. Thana's reflection has been occupied by the violator; her ego-image contains his body. The masquerade that follows is an attempt to repossess the mirror, to make her reflection a weapon rather than a site of invasion. bell hooks's notion of the "oppositional gaze" (1992), the critical looking of Black women spectators who refuse identification with the white woman as object, marks the limits of any easy celebration of Thana's look: her repossessed gaze remains white, and Chapter Four has shown how readily it borrows the culture's racializing codes.

5.2 *The Death of the Photographer*

An arrogant fashion photographer invites Thana to be photographed; she kills him. Susan Sontag's *On Photography* (1977) proposed that the camera is a sublimation of the gun and that photographing someone is a sublimated, soft murder, as the vocabulary of shooting, loading, and aiming already confesses. Thana desublimates the apparatus: she returns the camera to the gun. Within the fashion chain traced in Chapter One, the photographer occupies the station of the image, where the seamstress's invisible labor becomes visible femininity. His death is the death of the machine that converts her work into display.

Michael Powell's *Peeping Tom* (1960) furnishes the inverse template: a cameraman murders women with a blade concealed in his tripod while filming their terror, and fits his camera with a mirror so that they watch their own deaths. *Ms .45* turns the scenario around, making the apparatus the victim and the woman its executioner. But the inversion has a limit that the film itself exposes. The diegetic photographer can be killed; the camera that photographs Thana, her beauty, her violation, and her killings, cannot. His death is a sacrificial substitution for an apparatus beyond the reach of any character, and that apparatus has an author.

5.3 *The Unpunished Author*

Ferrara plays the first, masked rapist under the name "Jimmy Laine," the same pseudonym under which he had played the homicidal painter of *The Driller Killer*. Hitchcock's cameos were signatures, the author appearing as a witness; Ferrara's is a confession, the author appearing as the originary violator. The confession is also an alibi. The first assailant is the only violator Thana's weapon never reaches; he returns only as a hallucination in her mirror. The frame protects him. Every man she kills is a substitute for the one she cannot find, and the one she cannot find is the one who made her.

The structure is theological before it is meta-cinematic. Chapter Two argued that the film belongs to the genre of theodicy; here the theodicy acquires its

hidden God. The author is the *deus absconditus* of the diegesis, masked, extradiegetic, the creator of a world in which violation is the first event and himself its first agent. Thana's war against men is, at its limit, a war against a creator she cannot see. The film knows this and stages it, which is its honesty; it also exempts him, which is its bad faith. Its self-indictment and its self-protection are the same gesture.

Carol Clover argued that rape-revenge films solicit from their male viewers a cross-gender identification with the victim and, through her, with a revenge directed at men like themselves; Gaylyn Studlar's *In the Realm of Pleasure* (1988) proposed a masochistic aesthetic as an alternative to Mulvey's sadistic model. The director's cameo literalizes both accounts. The man behind the camera inserts himself as the first object of the revenge he then withholds from himself, and the grindhouse spectator consumes his own punishment as pleasure while remaining, like the author, outside its range.

The unpunished author is not only a structure internal to *Ms .45*. In 1977 Roman Polanski, whose *Repulsion* (1965) is one of the European films against which this dissertation reads *Ms .45* (Chapter Six), was charged in Los Angeles with drugging and raping a thirteen-year-old girl. Under a plea agreement he pleaded guilty to unlawful sexual intercourse with a minor, and in February 1978, before sentencing, he fled to France; he has remained beyond the reach of American courts ever since. When Swiss authorities arrested him on the American warrant in 2009, more than a hundred figures from the film world signed a petition for his release, and Switzerland declined to extradite him the following year. The director of a canonical film about a woman who kills men was himself an unpunished violator, and his profession rallied to his defense. Ferrara's cameo stages inside a fiction what the Polanski case displays outside one: authorship as a shelter that the law did not breach.

5.4 *Defacement: Levinas at the Masquerade*

For Emmanuel Levinas, in *Totality and Infinity* (1961), the face of the Other is not a phenomenon among others but an epiphany whose first expression is the command not to murder; in later interviews he called the face that which forbids us to kill. *Ms .45* opens with a defacement. The first violence is committed by a man without a face, and the ethical command is suspended at the origin: Thana is denied any face-to-face with the agent of her injury, who remains unrepresentable. A vengeance that cannot meet a face is condemned to meet categories.

The film closes at a masquerade. The men at the Halloween party wear costumes, their faces displaced by signs, and the command of the face is muffled everywhere. Thana, by contrast, wears a nun's habit, whose wimple is an icono-

graphic frame for a face exposed in white. At the climax, the only fully disclosed face in the room is the killer's. Laurie strikes from behind, without a face-to-face. Thana turns, and for the first time in the film she meets a face, a woman's, and obeys its command: she does not fire. Levinasian ethics is fulfilled at the instant of its impossibility.

Michel Foucault's *The Order of Things* (1966) closed by prophesying that man would be erased like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. The masquerade stages that anti-humanist erasure as a party, and the turn toward Laurie stages its Levinasian refutation. The climax of *Ms .45* is thus the site of a quarrel between the end of man and the epiphany of the face, a quarrel the film resolves only by killing the one who heard the command.

VI

CHAPTER SIX

Sparagmos in the Refrigerator: Abjection, Dismemberment, and the Domestic Economy of Revenge

6.1 *The Abject Household*

Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) defined the abject as that which disturbs identity, system, and order, neither subject nor object, and named the corpse as the utmost of abjection: death infecting life. *Ms .45* stages abjection as housekeeping. The burglar is dismembered in Thana's bathtub; his parts are sealed in plastic bags and stored in the refrigerator, the appliance whose function is to preserve food; when she showers, organs and fluids overflow the drain. The boundary between the body and the home has failed, and the violator refuses to leave. The domestic interior, ideologically the woman's sphere and the space of her safety, becomes an archive of the abject.

Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) defined dirt as matter out of place, and pollution as the threat that anomalous things pose to classificatory order. Thana disposes of the bags across the city, and the media's horror at the limbs is the horror of misclassification: a person found among refuse. Her act is a classificatory revenge. Rape, in Andrea Dworkin's account in *Pornography: Men Possessing Women* (1981), published in the year of the film, reduces a woman to a thing possessed. Thana returns the reduction, reclassifying the violator from person to waste, and distributes him through the circulatory system of the city's garbage.

Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) traced the *unheimlich* to the *heimlich*, the strange to the familiar made strange. Two European films frame the American one. In Roman Polanski's *Repulsion* (1965), Carol, a manicurist who works in an industry of feminine appearance, disintegrates in a London flat where hands emerge from the walls to seize her, as Thana's assailant emerges in her mirror; the apartment is a projected psyche. Chantal Akerman's *Jeanne Dielman, 23 quai du Commerce, 1080 Bruxelles* (1975) renders domestic labor in ritual duration

until a minute disturbance of routine ends in the killing of a client with a pair of scissors. Jeanne's scissors and Thana's iron are instruments of the same hands: the violence of both films originates in the routinized labor of women, and its weapons are the tools of that labor.

6.2 *Sparagmos Without Thiasos*

In Euripides' *Bacchae* (405 BCE), Pentheus, king of Thebes, wishes to spy on the women's Dionysian rites; persuaded by the god to disguise himself as a woman, he is discovered and torn apart by the Maenads, led by his own mother, Agave, who carries his head home believing it a lion's. The voyeur is dismembered by women under cover of a festival in which costume dissolves identity. *Ms .45* distributes the elements of this rite across its narrative: the photographer-voyeur is killed, the violator is dismembered, and the festival of costumes becomes the scene of the final massacre. One element is missing. The Maenads are a *thiasos*, a collective possessed by the god; Thana is alone and lucid. Hers is a *sparagmos* without *thiasos*, the same subtraction that made her a Philomela without Procne.

Plutarch's account of Isis and Osiris offers the inverse paradigm. Set dismembers Osiris and scatters the pieces across Egypt; Isis searches out and reassembles them, and, the phallus being lost, fashions a replica to replace it. Isis gathers; Thana scatters. Isis fabricates the missing phallus; Thana appropriates one. The goddess re-members a body, in the strong sense that weaving re-members fibers into a fabric, and the seamstress dis-members one. The opposition between gathering and scattering is the mythic form of the opposition between the hyphantic and the ballistic that this dissertation pursues.

6.3 *The Bath: Clytemnestra, Corday, Judith*

In Aeschylus' *Agamemnon* (458 BCE), Clytemnestra kills her husband in the bath, entangling him in a woven robe cast over him like a net, in revenge for the sacrifice of their daughter. The textile and the bath appear together at the origin of tragic female vengeance: the garment is the weapon, and the place of bodily purification is the place of slaughter. When Charlotte Corday stabbed Marat in his bath in July 1793, Jacques-Louis David answered with a pietà of the Revolution, and Lamartine later fixed upon her the epithet "the angel of assassination." The film's international title, *Angel of Vengeance*, joins a lineage of angelic women whose violence the culture could narrate only by sanctifying or demonizing it.

The Book of Judith supplies the closest typological precedent. Judith enters the Assyrian camp, takes down Holofernes' own sword from the bedpost, and beheads him with it; she then hands the head to her maid, who carries it away,

in the King James Apocrypha's phrasing, in a "bag of meat" (Judith 13:6–10). The violator's own weapon, the severed body, the bag of food: every element returns in *Ms .45*, where the rapist's gun becomes the avenger's and his remains are bagged and refrigerated. One element does not return. Judith has a maid, an accomplice who holds the bag. Thana has no one.

Artemisia Gentileschi, raped in 1611 by the painter Agostino Tassi, was subjected by the court during the ensuing trial to judicial torture with thumbscrews to test the truth of her testimony: the law, too, held that pain would make a woman talk. Her *Judith Slaying Holofernes* paintings make the maid an active collaborator, pinning the general down as Judith cuts. Mary Garrard's *Artemisia Gentileschi* (1989) read these images as figures of female heroism and solidarity; Griselda Pollock cautioned against reducing them to biographical revenge fantasies. The debate is exemplary for *Ms .45*: criticism has oscillated between reading the film as revenge fantasy and reading its formal intelligence, and the Artemisian paintings, like the film, reward the second reading without refuting the first.

6.4 *The Nose and the Dog*

The landlady's name, Nasone, is Italian for "big nose," and her dog, Phil, is drawn by scent to Thana's refrigerator. She is played by Editta Sherman, a celebrated portrait photographer: the film's one photographer who is a woman is also the one figure of surveillance it spares. Freud speculated in *Civilization and Its Discontents* that the adoption of upright posture devalued smell and set organic repression in motion, and that the dog, an animal of smell unashamed of excrement and sex, lends its name as a term of abuse for that reason. Phil's nose is the organ of the repressed abject: the dog smells the truth that the city, which only sees, cannot.

Thana grinds part of the dead rapist's body into hamburger and feeds it to Phil, the Philomelan banquet displaced onto an animal and inverted, since in Ovid the violator is made to eat and here the violator is what is eaten, and then ties him to a post by the river and spares him. The landlady, finding the burglar's head, assumes the dog is dead and calls the police; the coda shows her mourning her husband and her dog at a memorial, while the dog, alive, scratches at her door. The comic subplot is the film's countervoice. The old widow's nosiness is a degraded form of care, the last organ of attention in a community that otherwise does not see Thana at all. In a film without sisters, the landlady is the woman who notices her, and she does so through the nose of a dog whose name means love.

VII

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Unconverted Fury: Revenge, Law, and the Critique of Violence from Aeschylus to Benjamin

> "Revenge is a kind of wild justice; which the more man's nature runs to, the more ought law to weed it out." — Francis Bacon, "Of Revenge" (1625)

7.1 *Wild Justice and the Absent Court*

Bacon's aphorism states the classical settlement: vengeance is justice in its untamed form, and law is the gardener that weeds it out. Susan Jacoby's *Wild Justice: The Evolution of Revenge* (1983), published two years after the film, argued that civilization does not abolish the desire for retribution but channels it into law, and that where institutions deny legitimate retribution, the wild form returns. The vigilante cinema of the 1970s is a symptom of that return, and *Ms .45* specifies its gendered ground. Into the 1970s, American rape law remained shaped by Sir Matthew Hale's seventeenth-century warning that rape is an accusation easily made and hard to disprove, by corroboration and resistance requirements, and by the marital exemption; the reform movement that produced rape shield statutes, beginning with Michigan's in 1974, was still remaking the field when the film was shot.

The film's most eloquent statement about law is an omission. Thana never considers going to the police, and the film never considers it for her. The public avenger of Romans 13 is so thoroughly absent from her world that his absence is not even represented. Wild justice does not here rebel against an existing court; it grows where no court has been planted.

7.2 *The* Oresteia *and the Patroness of Weaving*

Aeschylus' *Oresteia* (458 BCE) is the West's founding drama of the passage from vengeance to law. The Erinyes, ancient female powers of blood-retribution, pursue Orestes for killing his mother; Athena convenes the Areopagus; Apollo argues that the mother is not the true parent but only the nurse of the seed; and Athena, born from her father's head without a mother, casts the deciding vote for Orestes, declaring herself for the male in all things. The Furies are persuaded to accept honored residence beneath the city as the Eumenides, the Kindly Ones. Froma Zeitlin's "The Dynamics of Misogyny" (1978) read the trilogy as a mythic charter for patriarchal order, in which the founding of law coincides with the subordination of female, chthonic, blood-bound justice to male, civic, rational justice.

Thana is an unconverted Fury, risen from beneath a city whose court has failed her. Yet the analogy discloses a difference. The Erinyes avenge kin-blood; theirs is the justice of kinship. Thana avenges a wrong done to herself and, by extension, to women as a class. Her vengeance therefore does not express an existing kinship but gropes toward constructing one, a kinship of injury that has no name until the film's last word supplies it. The Fury finds her kin only at the moment of death.

The goddess who subordinates the Furies is also the patroness of weaving. Athena Ergane presides over the loom, and in Ovid it is she who destroys Arachne's tapestry of divine rapes. The hyphantic is therefore not innocently liberatory. Weaving can be the craft of the order, Athena's, or the craft of testimony, Arachne's and Philomela's; the same art that dresses the city can expose its crimes. Any humanism built upon the figure of the loom must reckon with Athena as well as Arachne, and Chapter Twelve takes this as a constraint.

7.3 *Benjamin: Mythic Violence Without a Myth*

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) distinguishes the violence that makes law from the violence that preserves it, gathering both under the name of mythic violence, and opposes to them a divine violence that destroys law, expiates, and strikes without bloodshed. The state monopolizes violence, Benjamin argues, not to protect particular ends but to protect law itself, which is why the figure of the "great criminal" arouses the public's secret admiration: his violence exposes the violent foundation that law conceals. Benjamin's paradigm of mythic violence is Niobe, whose children are slain and who is left alive and petrified, a weeping stone marking the boundary of the law. Niobe's story stands in the same sixth book of the *Metamorphoses* as Arachne's and Philomela's. Ovid's book of silenced and transformed women is an anthology of the figures *Ms .45* condenses.

Thana is a great criminal in Benjamin's sense: the cult the film acquired attests to the fascination of a violence that exposes law's default. But her violence fits none of his categories. It makes no law, since it founds no order and gathers no adherents. It preserves none. It is not divine, since it is bloody, strikes by association, and expiates nothing. It is mythic violence without a myth: punitive yet non-founding, a violence that, instead of fixing a boundary stone like Niobe, erases every boundary in the entropy charted in Chapter Four. Jacques Derrida's "Force of Law" (1990) dwelt on the undecidability between founding and preserving violence and, in a postscript, warned against the seductions of Benjamin's divine violence. That warning applies to criticism that would sanctify Thana's bloodshed as messianic: the film itself refuses the sanctification by ending in a stabbing rather than an apotheosis.

7.4 *Ressentiment, Repetition, and the "It Was"*

Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887) traced slave morality to *ressentiment*, the reaction of those denied the true reaction of deeds, who compensate with an imaginary revenge. Thana's revenge is not imaginary, and by Nietzsche's typology she escapes the impotence of ressentiment. Zarathustra's discourse "On Redemption," however, gives revenge a deeper definition: it is the will's ill will against time and its "It was." Since the will cannot will backward, it takes revenge upon whatever can suffer. Thana's campaign is ill will against the "It was" of her rapes. The past cannot be unmade, so the present is punished without limit, which is why the campaign has no internal principle of termination. Zarathustra's hope that man might be delivered from revenge names the bridge the film cannot build.

Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) offers the clinical form of the same structure. The repetition compulsion returns to unpleasurable experience, and the child's game of *fort-da*, throwing away and retrieving a spool, converts the passivity of a mother's departure into the activity of a staged one. Thana's killings are a *fort-da* in blood, repeating the scene of violation with the roles reversed. Her name abbreviates the drive Freud's later theory set against Eros, and the film contains no Eros at all: desire appears only as violation or as lure.

Jean Améry's essay "Resentments" (1966) defends the victim against Nietzsche. Resentment, for Améry, is a moral protest against the natural time that heals and forgets; it demands, absurdly but rightly, that the past be undone, and that the perpetrator be bound to his deed until he, too, recognizes its moral truth. Thana's violence externalizes Améry's refusal of healing time. But Améry's resentment seeks recognition, and her victims recognize nothing. Even resentment

in its most dignified form presupposes a circuit of address, and violence severs that circuit at the moment it seeks to enforce it.

7.5 *The Festival and the Scapegoat*

René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) describes violence as mimetic and escalating until a sacrificial crisis, a collapse of the differences that structure a community, is resolved by the unanimous expulsion of a scapegoat whose death restores order. Festivals reenact the crisis ritually, through masks, inversions, and license, and culminate in sacrifice. The Halloween party is such a festival. Costumes abolish distinctions; Thana's indiscriminate fire is the crisis of undifferentiation in its purest form; and her stabbing by Laurie is the scapegoat mechanism, in which the victim of the founding violence becomes the sacrificial victim whose death returns the community to order. The knife comes from the cake table: the instrument of commensality becomes the sacrificial blade.

Girard later argued, in *The Scapegoat* (1982), that myth is written from the persecutors' standpoint and silences its victims, whereas the biblical texts reveal the mechanism by giving the victim a voice. The last seconds of *Ms .45* perform that revelation. The scapegoat speaks, and what she speaks is not an accusation but the name of a bond. Martha Nussbaum's *Anger and Forgiveness* (2016) urged anger's "Transition" from the fantasy of payback toward forward-looking concern. Thana never makes the Transition. The film's one forward-looking word is uttered by someone who has no future, and it is to that word that the argument must now turn by way of the politics of insurgent violence.

VIII

CHAPTER EIGHT

Rebellion and Its Limit: Fanon, Sartre, Solanas, Dworkin, Camus, Arendt

8.1 *The Violence of the Oppressed*

Frantz Fanon's *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961) opens with the claim that decolonization is always a violent phenomenon, and argues that at the level of individuals violence is a cleansing force, freeing the colonized from an inferiority complex, from despair and inaction, and restoring self-respect. Jean-Paul Sartre's preface radicalized the claim: the colonized heals himself of colonial neurosis through violence, and in killing a colonizer destroys at once the oppressor and the oppressed in himself, leaving a dead man and a free man. *Ms .45* registers a Fanonian exhilaration with disquieting fidelity. After the first killings Thana acquires composure, mobility, and a hard glamour; she walks the night unafraid. At the level of affect, the cleansing appears real.

The analogy between colonial and patriarchal domination must nevertheless be handled with care. Feminist and postcolonial critics, from Spivak to Kimberlé Crenshaw's "Mapping the Margins" (1991), have shown how such analogies erase women who live both dominations at once, and the film's own targeting of a Saudi businessman shows how quickly an emancipatory analogy can borrow the reflexes of empire. Fanon's "Algeria Unveiled" (1959) offers a more precise and more troubling precedent. It describes Algerian women who used the veil, and its strategic removal, as cover for carrying weapons through checkpoints, their dress becoming an instrument of insurgency. Thana's nun's habit, a religious veil concealing a pistol, belongs to this genealogy of tactical costume, and so does the critique that Fanon's essay instrumentalized women's bodies for a struggle whose victory did not liberate them.

8.2 *SCUM and the Manifesto Without Words*

Valerie Solanas's *SCUM Manifesto* (1967), a manifesto calling for the destruction of the male sex, in terms whose literalness its readers have never settled, acquired its notoriety when its author shot Andy Warhol in New York in 1968. Avital Ronell's introduction to the 2004 edition, "Deviant Payback," read Solanas as a philosophical provocateur rather than a merely pathological case. The comparison clarifies what *Ms .45* is not. Solanas's text argues, mocks, legislates, and imagines; it is a manifesto that preceded a shooting. Thana's campaign is a shooting that never becomes a manifesto. Her violence is propaganda of the deed without propaganda: it addresses no public and articulates no program, and no one who witnesses it understands what it means.

Andrea Dworkin's 1983 address to a men's conference, "I Want a Twenty-Four-Hour Truce During Which There Is No Rape," asked for the briefest of ceasefires in a war she believed most men did not know they were waging. Her novel *Mercy* (1990) ends with its narrator, after a lifetime of violation, turning to violence against men in the streets of New York, a fictional record of the despair of a feminism of testimony that has not been heard. *Mercy* and *Ms .45* share a city and a terminus, but they arrive there from opposite directions. Dworkin's narrator turns to violence after the failure of speech; Thana turns to violence without ever having had speech to fail.

8.3 *Self-Defense and the Law: The Cases of the 1970s*

The film was made in the wake of trials that turned women's self-defense into a feminist cause. Inez García testified that in 1974 Luis Castillo raped her with Miguel Jiménez's help; shortly afterward she shot and killed Jiménez, and she told the court she regretted only having missed Castillo. Convicted of second-degree murder, she had the conviction reversed on appeal and was acquitted at retrial in 1977 on a theory of self-defense. Joan Little, a twenty-year-old Black prisoner in a North Carolina county jail, killed Clarence Alligood, a sixty-two-year-old white jailer, in 1974 with the ice pick he had brought into her cell; by her account he had forced a sexual act on her at its point. She was acquitted in 1975 after a national campaign, and her case joins Judith's pattern to Thana's: the violator's own weapon, turned against him. In *State v. Wanrow* (1977), a case in which Yvonne Wanrow, a Colville woman on crutches, shot and killed William Wesler, a man she believed had sexually abused a child and was threatening her son, when he entered at night the house where she was staying with children, the Washington Supreme Court held that self-defense must be judged from the standpoint of a woman in the defendant's circumstances rather than by a stan-

dard calibrated to men. Feminist legal scholarship, notably Elizabeth Schneider's, would build on these cases.

Thana's first killing belongs to that jurisprudence; every subsequent killing departs from it. The film can be read as a demonstration of the lines that the law of self-defense draws, imminence, necessity, proportionality, and of their successive crossing: from the defense of a body in the act of violation, to the preemptive killing of an ambiguous pursuer, to the punishment of men who resemble the violator, to the massacre of men as such. The film does not argue that the lines are wrong. It shows what becomes of a person for whom no institution has drawn them.

8.4 *Camus: I Rebel, Therefore We Are*

Albert Camus's *The Rebel* (1951) begins with the rebel's "no" and discovers in it an implicit "yes": a limit, a value in the name of which the rebel refuses, and therefore a human nature shared with others. Rebellion, Camus argued, has its own cogito, and it is plural: I rebel, therefore we exist. When rebellion forgets its origin it degenerates through metaphysical revolt and nihilism into logical crime, murder justified by reason. In *The Just Assassins* (1949), the revolutionary Kaliayev refuses to throw his bomb at the Grand Duke's carriage because children are inside; he kills later, and accepts his own death as the price of having killed.

Thana's trajectory traverses Camus's genealogy in eighty minutes, from the "no" of the iron to the indiscriminate fire of the party. Her rebellion lacks the "we"; it is a cogito in the singular, and its degeneration follows from that lack. Yet the film grants her two Kaliayev moments. She spares the dog, and she does not fire on Laurie. Like Kaliayev, she dies at the limit she honors. And her last word restores, in extremis, the plural that her rebellion had lacked: "Sister!" is Camus's cogito spoken as a scream.

8.5 *Arendt: The Web and the Missing "In Concert"*

Hannah Arendt's *On Violence* (1970) was written against the glorification of violence on the New Left, and explicitly against Sartre's preface, while noting that Fanon himself was more ambivalent than his prefacer. Power, Arendt argued, corresponds to the human ability to act in concert; it belongs to a group and lasts only as long as the group holds together; violence is instrumental, and can destroy power but never create it. *The Human Condition* (1958) adds a textile figure: action and speech take place within an already existing "web" of human relationships, and power springs up between people when they act together and vanishes when they disperse.

Arendt's distinction is the hinge of this dissertation, and *Ms .45* proves it by subtraction. Two contemporaneous works supply the positive term. Lizzie Borden's *Born in Flames* (1983) imagines a New York in which a Women's Army organizes across lines of race and class, broadcasts on pirate radio, rides in bicycle brigades to interrupt assaults, and finally destroys a media transmitter atop the World Trade Center. Its women speak incessantly, and their violence, coordinated and aimed at infrastructure rather than bodies, is the instrument of a power that already exists among them. Monique Wittig's *Les Guérillères* (1969) imagines a war of women that is also a war on language, an epic of lists and names that refounds the world in a new idiom. In both, violence follows speech and serves a collective; in *Ms .45*, violence replaces speech and serves no one.

The film's final word is the first syllable of power. Addressed to another woman, it is the minimal act of speech that could have begun an acting-in-concert, the first thread of a web. It is spoken at the moment the violence ends, and by a speaker who will not survive it. Arendt's distinction between power and violence is thus rendered by the film not as a theorem but as a tragedy: the heroine discovers power only as she loses the capacity to exercise it.

IX

CHAPTER NINE

Habit, Habitus, Hallowmas: The Nun, the Martyr, and the Anti-Hagiography of Thana

9.1 *The Vigil of the Saints*

Halloween is All Hallows' Eve, the vigil of the Feast of All Saints, followed on the second of November by the commemoration of All Souls: a liturgical threshold between the canonized and the dead. Thana dies on the eve of the feast of the saints, and the coincidence is formal rather than decorative. The film is structured as a *passio*, the genre of the martyr's suffering and death, and it inverts each of the genre's terms. Medieval legends of the virgin martyrs, collected in Jacobus de Voragine's *Golden Legend* and studied by Karen Winstead, turn on threatened or inflicted sexual violence, steadfast resistance, and a death or miracle that preserves the virgin's integrity: Agnes consigned to a brothel and miraculously protected; Agatha, who had refused the governor Quintianus, mutilated at his command, her breasts cut off; Lucy, whom the governor Paschasius ordered taken to a brothel, rendered immovable. Their bodies are sites of assault that sanctity converts into testimony.

The modern exemplar of this tradition is Maria Goretti, an eleven-year-old girl stabbed to death in 1902 by Alessandro Serenelli, a twenty-year-old neighbor, when she resisted his attempt to rape her; she forgave him before she died and was canonized in 1950 as a martyr of purity, proposed to the postwar Catholic world as a model. Thana is an anti-Goretti. She survives violation rather than dying in resistance, takes vengeance rather than forgiving, and is killed not by a violator but by a woman. *Bad Lieutenant*, co-written by the actress who played her, returns to the Goretti paradigm through its forgiving nun. The two films of the diptych thus divide between them the possible relations of a violated woman to sanctity: martyrdom by forgiveness, and an anti-hagiography in which the saint's iconography is worn as a disguise for killing.

9.2 *The Habit Triad*

The nun's habit is the film's densest signifier, and its density is etymological. Latin *habitus*, from *habere*, to have or hold oneself, signifies at once a garment, a bodily bearing, and a settled disposition. Three senses converge on the costume Thana wears to her death.

Vestment. Thomas Carlyle's *Sartor Resartus* (1833–34), "the tailor re-tailored," expounds through its fictional Professor Teufelsdröckh a philosophy of clothes: society and its institutions rest upon cloth, all symbols are garments, and man is a clothed animal whose sanctities are vestments he has forgotten are woven. The seamstress who manufactures the city's clothing puts on its most sacred garment as a costume, and Carlyle's satire becomes literal: the vestment of holiness is revealed as fabric, and the fabric conceals a gun. This is the sense in which the dissertation's title calls Thana *sartrix resarta*, the seamstress re-sewn by her own work.

Disposition. Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics* (Book II) defines virtue as a *hexis*, a settled state formed by repeated acts: we become just by doing just things. Aquinas systematizes the doctrine of *habitus* (*Summa Theologiae* I–II, qq. 49–54), in which virtues and vices are good and bad habits, second natures acquired through action. Thana becomes a killer by killing; the film is a negative *Ethics*, a formation in vice whose terminus is the donning of the garment that names the disposition. Pierre Bourdieu's *habitus*, in *Outline of a Theory of Practice* (1972) and *Masculine Domination* (1998), names the dispositions that social structures inscribe in bodies, and the symbolic violence by which domination is misrecognized as nature in posture, gaze, and gait. Thana's transformation ruptures a feminine habitus of lowered eyes and contained movement, but only by incorporating a masculine habitus of violence. She does not escape the order of habitus; she changes orders, and the habit at the party is the ironic sign of a new profession.

Compulsion. In its third sense habit names repetition beyond choice. Freud's repetition compulsion has already been invoked; the Ferrara–St. John corpus would later make compulsion its explicit subject in *The Addiction* (1995), in which a philosophy student infected with vampirism experiences evil as dependency. Thana's killings acquire the regularity of a compulsion, nightly and ritualized, until the habit becomes the only garment she can wear.

Bad Lieutenant had already made addiction the medium of its protagonist's fall and grace. Lund, its co-writer, spoke publicly about her own heroin use, and she appears in the film in a scene of shared heroin use with the Lieutenant, delivering a monologue on self-consumption. The diptych's division between the believer and the actress therefore runs through the third sense of habit as well:

the screenwriter of *Ms .45* would write compulsion as allegory, while its star had already written it as a condition she publicly claimed as her own.

The triad is a knot: the garment displays the disposition, and the disposition has become a compulsion. In the nun's habit, the seamstress's labor, the formation of character by repetition, and the death drive's insistence are tied together and worn in public.

9.3 *Red Lips Beneath the Wimple*

Thana attends the party as a nun with red lipstick. The image conjoins the bride of Christ and the femme fatale, Mary and Eve, and so collapses onto a single body the split Freud described in "On the Universal Tendency to Debasement in the Sphere of Love" (1912), in which men cannot desire where they love or love where they desire. The collapse is lethal to the men who sustain the split. The image also belongs to a commercial iconography of profaned sanctity that the 1970s had made marketable, from Ken Russell's *The Devils* (1971) to the Italian and Japanese nunsploitation cycles. The film's most famous still, the habited woman with raised pistol, has circulated simultaneously as exploitation poster and feminist emblem, and has re-entered the festival it depicts as a Halloween costume in twenty-first-century popular culture. Its ambivalence is not a defect of reception; it is the image's structure.

Joan of Arc is the image's distant ancestor. The armed virgin was condemned by an ecclesiastical court at Rouen, presided over by Bishop Pierre Cauchon under English authority, in part for wearing men's clothing, a sartorial heresy, and burned in 1431; Carl Theodor Dreyer's *The Passion of Joan of Arc* (1928) rendered her trial as a cinema of faces. Thana inverts Joan's transgression. Joan took men's garments to fight; Thana takes the most sanctified of women's garments to kill. Both are judged by their clothing, and both die at the hands of the order whose costume they wear.

9.4 *Sacrament Without Grace*

Ms .45 contains no clergy, no sanctuary, and no sacrament. Its only sacred object is a costume, and its only rite is an office party. Whatever the origin of the screenwriter's pseudonym, "St. John" summons the visionary of Patmos, in whose Apocalypse angels pour out the vials of divine wrath upon the earth (Revelation 16:1); the film's international title, *Angel of Vengeance*, completes the summons. But the apocalypse here is without a God to authorize its angel. Catholic theology holds that grace does not abolish nature but perfects it. The world of *Ms .45* is nature without grace, a city in which nothing gratuitous occurs.

Except once. The hagiographic tradition from which the film borrows its iconography culminates in the martyr's last word to her killer: Goretti forgave Serenelli, who after twenty-seven years in prison sought her mother's forgiveness and ended his life in a Capuchin friary, so that her word found uptake; the nun of *Bad Lieutenant* forgives hers. Thana, too, addresses her killer with her last breath. The word is not forgiveness but kinship, and its tone is undecidable, accusation, recognition, and plea at once. The anti-hagiography thus ends with the one gesture of hagiography it retains, stripped of theology: the dying woman's word to the one who strikes her. If the film has a grace, it is this unmerited, unbidden act of naming, and Chapter Ten examines what it names.

X

CHAPTER TEN

"Sister!": Recognition, Sorority, and the Tragedy of the Remainder

10.1 *The Scene and Its Four Registers*

At the party, Albert takes Thana upstairs and attempts to seduce her; she shoots him. The guests who rush toward the gunshot find her stepping out with the pistol, and she opens fire on the men. Her coworker Laurie takes a knife from the cake table and stabs her in the back. Thana turns, aims at Laurie, and hesitates; she screams "Sister!" and falls dead. It is the only word she voices in the film.

The scene withholds three things. It does not disclose Laurie's motive: the defense of the men, self-preservation, mercy, or the reflex of an order restoring itself. It does not explain Thana's hesitation: recognition, exhaustion, or the gendered limit of a grammar whose one sign has never been addressed to a woman. And it does not fix the word's tone, which can be heard as accusation, recognition, appeal, or blessing. The costume overdetermines the word further. A nun is addressed as "Sister"; the woman in the habit calls her killer by the title her own costume claims. Four registers of the word coincide in a single scream: the familial (the sibling), the religious (the professed woman), the political (the sisterhood of the women's movement), and the mythic (Procne, the addressee Philomela's web was woven for).

10.2 *Anagnorisis*

Aristotle defines recognition as a change from ignorance to knowledge that produces love or hatred between persons marked for good or ill fortune, and he judges finest the recognition that coincides with reversal (*Poetics* 11). The ending of *Ms .45* satisfies the definition with severity. Recognition and reversal coincide, since the killer is killed at the moment she recognizes; and what is recognized

is *philia*, the bond Aristotle names, here in the form of kinship. Earlier the dissertation recalled that Aristotle's catalog of recognitions includes "the voice of the shuttle," the woven message through which Procne learned her sister's fate. *Ms .45* achieves its recognition without the shuttle, by voice alone, and in the wrong direction: it is not the sister who reads the victim's testimony, but the victim who names the sister as she dies. The recognition is unilateral. The film ends before Laurie can be shown to recognize anything, and the tragedy lies in the asymmetry.

10.3 *Recognition and Domination*

In the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807), Hegel argued that self-consciousness exists only in being recognized by another self-consciousness, that the struggle for recognition is a struggle to the death, and that a struggle ending in death fails, since the dead cannot recognize the victor. Thana's victories over men are Hegelian failures: each one abolishes the only being who could have acknowledged her. Hegel's bondsman achieves a measure of self-consciousness through formative labor, shaping the thing and thereby himself; Thana's labor forms garments that speak for their owner, not for her. Only when she loses the struggle does recognition occur, and it occurs from her side.

Jessica Benjamin's *The Bonds of Love* (1988) recast the master-slave dialectic in feminist psychoanalytic terms: domination arises when the tension between self-assertion and recognition of the other collapses, and mutual recognition is the alternative to the polarity of master and slave. Thana's campaign is assertion without recognition, and it hardens accordingly into domination. "Sister!" is the first offer of mutual recognition in the film, made at the instant when the tension it would have to sustain can no longer be sustained by anyone.

10.4 *Antigone, Ismene, Laurie*

Sophocles' Antigone defies Creon's edict to bury her brother, after her sister Ismene declines to join her on the ground that women cannot contend with men; Antigone declares herself born to join in love, not in hate. Hegel read the play as the collision of divine law, borne by the family and by woman, with human law, borne by the state and by man, and called womankind the everlasting irony of the community. Luce Irigaray's "The Eternal Irony of the Community" exposed the operation by which Hegel confined woman to blood and night; Judith Butler's *Antigone's Claim* (2000) read the heroine as a figure who unsettles the normative forms of kinship themselves.

The film rearranges the Sophoclean figures. Laurie occupies the position of Ismene, the sister who does not join, but in *Ms .45* it is Ismene who holds the blade, so that the sister becomes the hand of Creon. Thana occupies Antigone's position inversely. Antigone dies for an existing kin; Thana dies creating one. Antigone's claim of kinship precedes and motivates her transgression; Thana's arrives after hers, as its posthumous interpretation.

10.5 *Sisterhood Is Powerful?*

Robin Morgan's anthology *Sisterhood Is Powerful* (1970) gave the women's movement a slogan; Audre Lorde's *Sister Outsider* (1984) gave it a paradox, a kinship with the one outside. In "Uses of Anger" (1981), Lorde distinguished anger, a grief between peers whose object is change, from hatred, whose object is death and destruction. Thana's arc slides from the first to the second, and her last word returns her, for an instant, to the register of peers.

bell hooks's "Sisterhood: Political Solidarity Between Women" (1984) criticized a sisterhood premised on shared victimization, which reproduced the self-image of privileged white women and concealed differences of race and class, and proposed instead a solidarity grounded in political commitment. The dialectic here is exact. Thana addresses a woman who does not know her history and with whom she shares no known injury. Her sorority is premised on nothing but address. In that sense it anticipates hooks's corrective, kinship without identity of injury; but it has no political content at all, no commitment, no program, only a cry. It is the zero degree of solidarity: the address that would have to precede any program, and here can precede nothing.

10.6 *The Sororal Counterfactual: Glaspell and Gorris*

Susan Glaspell's *Trifles* (1916) and its story version, "A Jury of Her Peers" (1917), supply the counterfactual the film lacks. A farm wife is held for strangling her husband; the sheriff, the county attorney, and a neighboring farmer search the house for a motive and find none. The sheriff's wife and the farmer's wife, attending to "trifles," read the evidence in a quilt whose stitching has gone erratic, a birdcage with a broken door, and a canary with its neck wrung, hidden in a sewing box: the husband had killed the bird, his wife's one source of song, and she had killed him. The women conceal what they have read. Annette Kolodny's "A Map for Rereading" (1980) used the story to show how gendered communities of interpretation read differently. Glaspell's women are the voice of the shuttle heard by sisters, an Areopagus of women convened in a kitchen at a time

when women were widely barred from juries. The wrung canary belongs to the lineage of Philomela's nightingale: the bird is the violated woman's voice.

Marleen Gorris's *A Question of Silence* (1982), released the year after *Ms .45*, answers it point by point. Three women who do not know one another spontaneously and silently kill the male owner of a clothing boutique; one of them, Christine, does not speak at all. A female court psychiatrist comes to understand them and refuses to declare them insane, and at the trial the women, then the women in the gallery, and finally the psychiatrist, laugh at the prosecutor's reasoning. Gorris's film shares with Ferrara's the milieu of the garment trade, a mute woman, and lethal violence against a man, but it adds the three elements *Ms .45* subtracts: sorority among strangers, a woman who recognizes, and laughter. Hélène Cixous's "The Laugh of the Medusa" (1975) answered Freud's petrifying Medusa with one who, looked at straight on, is beautiful and laughing. Thana's face never laughs. Laughter requires company.

10.7 *The Sororal Remainder*

The concept toward which the dissertation has been moving can now be defined. The *sororal remainder* is what is left over when everything that violence can do has been done: a residue of address that violence occasions but cannot produce, assimilate, or command. In *Ms .45* it has five determinations.

1. **Linguistic.** It is a second sign. A grammar of one sign is not a language; with the shot and the word, difference is restored and language begins, at the instant the speaker ends.
2. **Political.** It is the first syllable of power in Arendt's sense and the plural of Camus's cogito: an address that could have begun an acting-in-concert.
3. **Ethical.** It is the Levinasian face-to-face, obeyed: the gun does not fire.
4. **Dramaturgical.** It is anagnorisis coinciding with peripeteia, the finest recognition by Aristotle's measure, and it is unilateral.
5. **Theological.** It is the martyr's last word to her killer, secularized: not forgiveness, but kinship.

One further determination turns the film back upon its beginning. Thana's second assailant promised that violation would make her talk. At the end, pain does make her talk, and the rapist's prophecy is fulfilled to the letter. But the word that pain produces is not the confession that violence extorts. It is the name of the bond that violence exists to destroy. Elaine Scarry showed that pain unmakes language; here pain makes a word, and the word refutes the prophecy in the act of fulfilling it. That is the tragedy of the remainder and its consolation

together: sorority appears in *Ms .45* only as the relation between a victim and her executioner, and yet it appears.

XI

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Constellations: Ms .45 *Among Feminist and Humanist Works*

11.1 *The Principle of Comparison*

The preceding chapters have drawn comparisons as the argument required them. This chapter assembles them into a constellation organized by a single variable: the relation between the avenging woman's voice and her relation to other women. The hypothesis is that across the field, the more a heroine speaks and the more her violence is shared with or exercised for another woman, the more her violence is able to mean; and that *Ms .45* occupies the field's limit case, a mute and solitary avenger whose single word is addressed to the woman who kills her.

11.2 *The Silent Avenger*

Accounts of the film's genesis commonly record that *Ms .45* was inspired by *Death Wish*, *Taxi Driver*, and Bo Arne Vibenius's *Thriller – A Cruel Picture* (1973), whose heroine, rendered mute by a childhood assault, is forced into prostitution and trains herself to take revenge. Vibenius supplies the mute avenger; Ferrara and St. John supply the textile trade, the city, and the final word. The Japanese revenge cinema of the same years offers instructive variations. In Shunya Ito's *Female Prisoner #701: Scorpion* (1972), Meiko Kaji's near-silent heroine makes silence a chosen defiance rather than a given condition; Thana's silence is the latter. In Toshiya Fujita's *Lady Snowblood* (1973), vengeance is inherited, conceived by a violated mother as a mandate for her daughter: a vertical sorority in which revenge passes from one woman to another. Thana has no such lineage. Her vengeance has no mother and no daughter, only a sister named too late.

11.3 *The Masculine Vigilante and Its Détournement*

The male vigilante speaks. Paul Kersey of *Death Wish* explains himself; Travis Bickle of *Taxi Driver* narrates his own descent in a diary voice-over and rehearses his violence before a mirror, interrogating his reflection in the most quoted monologue of the decade. Thana's mirror scenes are silent, and the presence in her mirror is not herself but her violator. Travis "rescues" a twelve-year-old prostitute who has not asked to be rescued, killing the men who exploit her; Thana kills a pimp beating a prostitute, without rescue, without speech, and without the redemptive public narrative that *Taxi Driver*'s ironic coda confers upon its hero. Both films share the racial anxieties of their city. In the Situationist sense, *Ms .45* performs a *détournement* of the vigilante form: it keeps the form's apparatus while transferring the gun to the body the form had treated as the occasion of male grievance, and it strips the form of the self-narration that had made its violence intelligible.

11.4 *From Solitude to Sorority*

The later history of the rape-revenge film can be read as a progressive restoration of the two elements *Ms .45* subtracts, voice and sorority.

Work	Year	The avenger's voice	Relation to other women	What the comparison shows
Ms .45 (Ferrara / St. John)	1981	Mute; one word at death	Alone; killed by a coworker she names "Sister!"	The limit case: violence without speech or sorority
I Spit on Your Grave (Zarchi)	1978	A writer by profession	Alone	Specific, rural perpetrators keep revenge indexical
A Question of Silence (Gorris)	1982	One of three women never speaks	Strangers who act together; a woman psychiatrist who understands	Sorority without acquaintance; collective laughter
Born in Flames (Borden)	1983	A chorus of voices and pirate radio	A multiracial Women's Army	Violence follows speech and serves a collective
Thelma & Louise (Scott / Khouri)	1991	Both speak	The first shot defends a friend from rape	The gun used sororally; the ending shared
Baise-moi (Despentes / Trinh Thi)	2000	Both speak	Two women bound by transgression	A sorority of violence without a program

Work	Year	The avenger's voice	Relation to other women	What the comparison shows
Monster (Jenkins)	2003	Speaks	Her lover helps secure her confession	Sororal betrayal, an analogue of Laurie
The Nightingale (Kent)	2018	Made to sing for the officers who abuse her	Allied with an Aboriginal tracker	Philomela's bird; solidarity across colonial division
Promising Young Woman (Fennell)	2020	Speaks; leaves scheduled messages	Avenges a friend	Posthumous testimony: a digital voice of the shuttle

The pattern confirms the hypothesis. *Thelma & Louise* fires its first shot on behalf of another woman and ends with two clasped hands; *Promising Young Woman* makes its heroine's revenge sororal from the outset and, after her death, delivers her testimony through messages timed to arrive when she can no longer speak, a technological voice of the shuttle. Virginie Despentes's essay *King Kong Théorie* (2006), written in the wake of *Baise-moi*, argued that women are trained to survive rape rather than to fight, and claimed for women a capacity for violence that culture forbids them to imagine. *Ms .45* imagined that capacity in 1981, and imagined it alone, which is why its heroine's violence could not mean what Despentes's does.

11.5 *Literary Feminisms: Philomela's Daughters*

Shakespeare's *Titus Andronicus* (c. 1592) explicitly rewrites Philomela: Lavinia, raped by Tamora's sons, Chiron and Demetrius, who then cut out her tongue and cut off her hands so that she can neither speak nor sew, names them by tracing letters in the sand with a staff, and is killed by her father in the play's final banquet. The play eliminates the shuttle and the sister alike, and its violated woman can testify only through a father who then destroys her. Maya Angelou's *I Know Why the Caged Bird Sings* (1969) recounts how, at eight, the narrator was raped by her mother's boyfriend, Mr. Freeman. She testified at his trial; he was convicted and quickly released, and soon afterward he was found dead, apparently kicked to death, a killing the memoir implies was carried out by her uncles. Believing that her words in court had killed him, she fell silent for years, until a woman, Mrs. Bertha Flowers, restored her to speech through literature read aloud. The structure is Lucretia's, in which a woman testifies and men kill, and Angelou's silence is the penance it exacts from testimony. Her arc inverts Thana's: from speech, through the conviction that speech is lethal, into muteness, and back to speech by way of a woman's care and a book. The caged bird

of her title joins Philomela's nightingale and Glaspell's canary in a single aviary of violated voices.

Glaspell's sororal jury, Wittig's guerrilla epic, Solanas's manifesto, and Dworkin's *Mercy* have been treated in earlier chapters. Taken together, they show that literary feminism has repeatedly imagined the violated woman's speech as a collective act, a reading, a list, a manifesto, a jury, and that *Ms .45* is the cinematic negative of that imagination.

11.6 *Humanisms*

Giovanni Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (1486) gave Renaissance humanism its emblem: the human as a chameleon, without fixed nature, who fashions itself into whatever form it chooses. Thana is a dark Pico, a self-fashioner who remakes herself through costume and conduct. Stephen Greenblatt's *Renaissance Self-Fashioning* (1980), published the year before the film, showed that self-fashioning is always achieved against an alien other and within relations of power, so that the self fashioned bears the imprint of the authority it opposes. Thana fashions herself against men, through the instrument of a man, and her self bears that imprint to the end.

Kant's formula of humanity forbids treating persons merely as means. Rape treats Thana as a means, and her vengeance treats men as means, as signs in a grammar. The film is a parable of reciprocal instrumentalization, the Kingdom of Ends inverted into a city of means. Sartre's "Existentialism Is a Humanism" (1946) held that existence precedes essence and that in choosing for myself I choose an image of the human for all; Thana's existence produces its essence by killing, and the image it chooses cannot be universalized without abolishing the human it claims to defend. Michel de Montaigne's essay "Of Cruelty" named cruelty the extreme of all vices; the film's cruelty is distributed so that no one in it escapes the charge.

Fanon closed *The Wretched of the Earth* by calling for a new humanism and a new human being, beyond the European humanism that had coexisted with massacre. Edward Said's *Humanism and Democratic Criticism* (2004) defended humanism as a practice of critique open to its own failures. Judith Butler's *Precarious Life* (2004) and *Frames of War* (2009) showed that the grievability of lives is distributed by frames; *Ms .45* reverses the misogynist frame, rendering its male dead ungrievable spectacle, and so exposes the frame's arbitrariness by inverting it. Butler's *The Force of Nonviolence* (2020) grounds a forceful nonviolence in social interdependence, the recognition that the life of the other is bound up with one's own. That recognition is the philosophical cognate of the sororal remainder, and it is the point of departure for the final chapter.

XII

CHAPTER TWELVE

Toward a Hyphantic Humanism

12.1 *The Negative Proof*

Ms .45 proves by subtraction. Each preceding chapter isolated an absence that organizes the film: Philomela without Procne, *sparagmos* without *thiasos*, Judith without her maid, a Fury without a court, a rebel without a "we," violence without concert, a performative without uptake, a vengeance without a face, a passion without grace. The absences are variations of a single lack, the lack of the other who receives. The film never shows what that other would have been; it shows, with mounting precision, what happens in its absence. In this it resembles the apophatic theology of the Christian Neoplatonists, for whom the divine could be approached only by negation. *Ms .45* is an apophatic text about the human, and its humanism is legible only in the outline of what it removes.

This chapter draws that outline into a positive account. The account is named *hyphantic humanism*, and it is proposed not as a gloss on the film but as an independent position in moral and political philosophy whose conditions the film makes visible.

12.2 *Text, Suture, Shuttle*

The vocabulary is chosen for its etymological precision. Greek *hyphainein* means to weave; a *hyphantēs* is a weaver, and *hyphos* is a web. Latin *texere*, to weave, yields *textus*, and with it text, textile, texture, and context; Latin *suere*, to sew, yields *sutura*. The seamstress is therefore not merely a figure for signification: her craft supplies its vocabulary. The resemblance between *hyphantic* and *hyphen*, whose Greek source means "under one," is a paronomasia rather than a shared root,

but a felicitous one, since the mark that joins two words is the minimal sign of what the theory describes.

Film theory has its own seamstress. Jacques-Alain Miller's "Suture" (1966) named the operation by which a subject is stitched into the chain of discourse that excludes it; Jean-Pierre Oudart (1969) transposed the concept to cinema, where shot and reverse shot stitch the spectator into the fiction while concealing the "absent one" whose gaze produces the image; Daniel Dayan, Stephen Heath, and Kaja Silverman extended the account over the following decade and a half. In *Ms .45* suture theory's absent one acquires a body and a mask. The author whose apparatus produces every image appears inside it as the first, masked violator, and he alone escapes (Chapter Five). The seamstress, whose trade is suture, cannot reach the absent one; she can only cut the bodies within the field. Her violence is anti-suture, a dismemberment of the fabric she was trained to join, and the film's own medium, which joins images by cutting them, reflects her contradiction. Montage is a seamstress's art practiced with the shears.

12.3 *Four Axioms*

First axiom: texture. The human is neither a substance, nor a self-fashioner, nor a sovereign legislator, but a texture: a fabric of addresses in which each thread is held by others. The axiom draws its warrant from three sources. Arendt located speech and action within an already existing web of human relationships, so that no one is the sole author of her own story. Levinas, in *Otherwise than Being* (1974), distinguished the Saying, the exposure of one to another that precedes all content, from the Said, the content that can be thematized and possessed. Butler has grounded ethics in a constitutive vulnerability that binds each life to others. On this account the first fact of the human is not the *cogito* but the vocative: one is addressed before one speaks, and named before one names. Thana enters the film addressed by others, by a title that calls her *Ms*, by men in the street, by an employer whose invitation she answers in writing; she leaves it addressing another for the first time. Her life is the passage from being addressed to addressing, and it ends on the threshold.

Second axiom: shuttle and shears. Concerted speech weaves power; violence is the shears, which can cut and cannot weave. The axiom restates Arendt in the vocabulary of the craft, and the craft adds a refinement her distinction lacks. Every weaver cuts; Atropos is one of the Fates; the seamstress's scissors are as necessary as her needle. The axiom therefore does not oppose violence to nonviolence. It distinguishes the cut that serves a weave from the cut that replaces one. The shot in *Thelma & Louise* that stops the rape of a friend, the Women's Army's sabotage of a transmitter in *Born in Flames*, and the defensive force recog-

nized in *State v. Wanrow* are cuts in the service of a web that already exists, and each remains answerable to it. Thana's violence after the first blow is a cut that substitutes for the web, and the film demonstrates what such cutting produces: entropy, solitude, and a death with no one to read it.

A corollary follows from Athena. Not every weave is just. The patroness of weaving founds the court that subordinates the Furies and destroys the tapestry that testifies to divine rape; the Garment District is a web, and so is the market in which the commodity speaks while its maker falls silent; Arachne, punished, becomes a spider whose web is a trap. Hyphantic humanism must therefore distinguish the *web of address*, in which threads hold one another reciprocally, from the *web of capture*, in which some threads hold and others are held. The theory carries its own critique: the image of the loom is as available to domination as to solidarity, and the test of a weave is whether those it binds can answer.

Third axiom: the remainder. Every act of violence leaves a residue of address that it cannot assimilate. In *Ms .45* the remainder appears three times: as the hesitation before the dog, the hesitation before Laurie, and the word. Each interrupts the projectile with recognition; none is produced by violence, though violence occasions all three. The normative consequence is institutional. A just order is one designed to receive remainders before they become last words, to hear the address while the speaker lives. Lorde's sequence from silence to language to action, which the film reverses, becomes a political program: institutions of hearing must stand between silence and action, so that language arrives first.

Fourth axiom: plural address. The proper form of humanist address is neither the honorific nor the caliber but the elective kinship term. The honorific *Ms* addresses the liberal individual, the subject whom C. B. Macpherson's *The Political Theory of Possessive Individualism* (1962) described as proprietor of her own person and capacities; the film shows how readily self-ownership passes into the ownership of a weapon, as the period migrates from honorific to caliber. The caliber addresses no one; it reduces a person to an instrument. "Sister!" belongs to a third order. It is kinship chosen rather than given, constituted in the act of address rather than presupposed by it, as in hooks's account of solidarity built on commitment rather than shared injury, and in Donna Haraway's injunction, in *Staying with the Trouble* (2016), to make kin, which she illustrates with string figures passed from hand to hand.

The fourth axiom yields the theory's sharpest formal distinction. The shot and the word are both performatives, but of opposite kinds. The ballistic performative is sovereign: it does what it says without needing anyone's answer. The sororal performative is dependent: it constitutes kinship only if the one addressed takes it up. Its success requires uptake, and it is therefore vulnerable, revocable, and shared. Hyphantic humanism is the ethics of the dependent performative.

12.4 *Among the Rivals*

Against liberal humanism, from Pico's self-fashioning chameleon to Kant's autonomous legislator, hyphantic humanism holds that the self is woven before it is owned, and it reads in *Ms .45* a parable of where self-possession can lead. Against the anti-humanism of Foucault and Althusser, it accepts the critique of the human as substance but refuses the erasure of the face, which persists as the point where threads cross: the masquerade of the final scene stages the anti-humanist erasure, and the turn toward Laurie refutes it. With the posthumanism of Haraway and Rosi Braidotti it shares a relational ontology and a refusal of human exceptionalism, and it includes the animal in the web: the film's last living creature is a dog, and Levinas's camp dog recognized human beings when men would not. It retains the word *humanism*, with Fanon and Said, because the vocative is a normative claim, a demand that another answer, and *the human* names the community of those who can be so claimed.

Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982), published the year after the film, set an ethics of care, attentive to relationships and responsibilities, against an ethics of justice framed in rights and rules, and traced the former through women's moral development. Hyphantic humanism shares care ethics' attention to relation but declines its psychology. It grounds relationality not in a feminine voice but in the structure of address, which is the condition of any voice and which includes the voiceless. Its nearest relative is Butler's ethics of nonviolence, to which it contributes two instruments: the criterion of the cut that serves the weave, and the theory of the remainder.

12.5 *Objections and Replies*

First objection: the reading credits an exploitation film with more than it knows. The reply is methodological. A symptomatic reading in Jameson's sense attributes no intention; it reconstructs the structure that a text's elements compose. The structure of *Ms .45* is too consistent to be accidental: a mute seamstress, an apple and an iron, a shirt torn from a mannequin, writing for the master and voice for the sister, a single word at death. Its authorship is also plural, divided among a believing screenwriter, a secular director, and a performer who would become an author in her own right. The film knows more than any one of them.

Second objection: hyphantic humanism counsels passivity before violence. It does not. The second axiom's criterion is not nonviolence but service to the weave; it affirms collective and sororal self-defense and the feminist jurisprudence of the 1970s. What it criticizes is violence that substitutes for address, and it

criticizes that violence because it fails the violated themselves: Thana dies alone, and her campaign generates no power for any woman.

Third objection: the theory romanticizes sisterhood and erases difference. The sororal remainder is constituted by address rather than identity; the corollary of the second axiom builds the critique of capture into the image of the web; and the film's own "Sister!" is spoken to the woman who has just stabbed her. The concept carries betrayal within it, as *Monster* and the figure of Laurie attest. With Lorde and Crenshaw, the theory treats sorority not as a given universality but as a vocative that must be renewed across difference, which is what *Sister Outsider* names.

Fourth objection: the theory metaphorizes disability. The reading has kept muteness literal. Thana writes; she is aphonic, not alinguistic; and the hyphantic order counts writing, gesture, sign, and textile as forms of address. The theory is explicitly anti-phonocentric. The tragedy of *Ms .45* is not that its heroine cannot speak but that no one receives what she communicates; the failure belongs to the receivers, not to her voice. Mitchell and Snyder's critique of narrative prosthesis is answered by locating the deficit in the community rather than in the body.

Fifth objection: the film's Orientalism and whiteness disqualify it as a feminist text. The objection is conceded in part and then generalized. The killing of the Saudi businessman and his driver is not an incidental lapse but a symptom of the semiotic entropy analyzed in Chapter Four: when ballistic speech loses its index, it fills with the culture's stereotypes. The observation holds well beyond this film. Violence emptied of its referent recruits ideology to supply one.

12.6 *Coda: The Dog at the Door*

The film does not end with Thana's death. Its last movement returns to the landlady, a widow mourning her husband and her dog at a memorial, and then to her door, where the dog, alive, has found its way home and scratches to be let in. The final gesture of *Ms .45* is neither a gunshot nor a word but a request at a threshold.

Hyphantic humanism is the decision to open such doors. The seamstress of the title cannot be avenged, and this dissertation has argued that vengeance was never the film's true subject. What remains possible is the work her trade names: to re-sew the fabric in which her one word could have been a first word rather than a last. *Sartrix resarta*, the seamstress re-sewn, names that task. It belongs not to her but to everyone addressed by what she said.

APPENDIX

A Semiotic Ledger of the Killings

The ledger tabulates the trajectory analyzed in Chapter Four, from index to noise, together with the two limits at which the gun does not fire. The order of the middle encounters follows the standard synopsis; the argument depends on their semiotic modes rather than on their exact sequence.

#	Target	Instrument	Semiotic mode	Gloss
1	The burglar who rapes her in her apartment	A small glass apple, then a clothes iron	Index	Defense contiguous with violation; the trade's own tool (Chapters 3, 6)
2	A young man who retrieves her dropped bag and pursues her	.45	Error	Paranoid anticipation; retrieval read as menace (Chapter 4)
3	An arrogant fashion photographer	.45	Icon	The apparatus of the image; the camera returned to the gun (Chapter 5)
4	A pimp assaulting a prostitute	.45	Icon	The traffic in women; rescue without rescue (Chapter 11)
5	Members of a gang closing in to assault her	.45	Icon, multiplied	Homosocial violence; the violator as a group (Chapter 4)
6	A Saudi businessman and his limousine driver	.45	Symbol	Orientalist code; death by association (Chapters 4, 12)
7	A jilted salesman in a bar	.45 jams; he takes it and shoots himself	Stammer	Uptake only as self-execution (Chapter 4)

#	Target	Instrument	Semiotic mode	Gloss
8	Phil, the landlady's dog	.45 drawn, not fired	Limit	The animal remainder (Chapters 4, 6)
9	Albert, her employer	.45	Return to origin	Violence returns to the site of production (Chapter 1)
10	The men at the Halloween party	.45	Noise	Sacrificial crisis; universal defacement (Chapters 5, 7)
11	Laurie, her coworker	.45 aimed, not fired	Limit	The face-to-face; "Sister!" (Chapter 10)

Read from top to bottom, the ledger shows the sign losing its referent row by row while two hesitations interrupt it. The last row is the only one in which the gun is aimed at a woman, and it is the only one in which the heroine speaks.

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Keywords

Ms .45 • Abel Ferrara • Nicholas St. John •
Zoë Lund (Zoë Tamerlis) • rape-revenge film • exploitation cinema •
American independent cinema • New York fiscal crisis •
Garment District labor history • feminist film theory • the male gaze •
masquerade • muteness and voice •
disability and narrative prosthesis • phonocentrism • Philomela •
Arachne • the voice of the shuttle • textile metaphor •
suture theory • anagnorisis • ballistic grammar • semiotic entropy •
speech act theory • uptake • sororal remainder •
sisterhood and political solidarity • recognition (*Anerkennung*) •
power and violence • critique of violence • revenge and *ressentiment* •
repetition compulsion • scapegoat mechanism • abjection •
sparagmos • the face (Levinas) • Catholic moral theology •
virgin martyrs • anti-hagiography • habitus •
Lucretia and the origins of humanism • Renaissance self-fashioning •
possessive individualism • posthumanism • ethics of care •
ethics of nonviolence • grievability • Orientalism •
intersectionality • hyphantic humanism